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DMRC proposes new FOB at Pitampura metro station

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) has prepared a proposal to build a foot overbridge (FOB) across the Outer Ring Road to improve access to the Pitampura-Prashant Vihar Metro Station, following intervention by Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta.

Officials said the proposal has been sent to the Public Works Department for approval. The planned bridge is expected to provide direct and safer connectivity for residents coming from Prashant Vihar and Rohini. The move comes after several Residents' Welfare Associations raised concerns about poor access to the metro station. Complaints highlighted that commuters from the Prashant Vihar side have no direct entry and are forced to take longer routes, causing inconvenience.

The Speaker had taken up the matter with the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation after receiving representations, including from a senior citizens' welfare group. He had urged authorities to ensure safe and barrier-free access, especially for elderly people, persons with disabilities, and patients. At present, the station is accessible mainly from the Pitampura side. This has led to difficulties for residents living across the Outer Ring Road, particularly along the Majlis Park to Deepali Chowk stretch.



In response, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation said it has prepared a feasibility plan for the construction of a foot overbridge. However, the project requires certain technical adjustments before it can be implemented.

Officials said the design must meet safety standards, including height requirements under an existing flyover maintained by the Public Works Department. This may require changes in road geometry to ensure compliance with engineering norms. The proposal is currently under consideration with the Public Works Department. Construction will begin only after the necessary approvals are granted.

Apart from the bridge, the metro authority has also proposed additional pedestrian-friendly measures. These include a zebra crossing near one of the station entry points to improve at-grade access for commuters. Officials added that a lift facility from ground level to the concourse is already available at the station. These features are part of a larger plan aimed at improving multimodal connectivity.

The broader plan has been submitted to the Unified Traffic and Transportation Infrastructure Planning and Engineering Centre for review. Implementation will be carried out by the concerned road-owning agency once approvals are in place. Reacting to the development, Gupta said the proposal is a step in the right direction but stressed the need for comprehensive solutions. He said public transport systems must be accessible to all sections of society. "Safe and easy access should be ensured for every citizen, especially senior citizens," he said. He also called for faster action so that residents can benefit from improved connectivity without delay.

contact." However, they only gave him a written warning and sent him on paid leave. The victim employee was further subjected to sexual harassment by the CEO of the company.

Meanwhile, the survivor alleged that she faced a "digital lockdown" in February 2026, when her office email was blocked, and was informed via text on March 6, 2026, not to come to the office. The survivor, through her advocate Apoorva Pandey, appealed and argued before the Industrial Tribunal at Rouse Avenue, and Judge Manjusha Wadhwa issued orders on March 12 and April 17, 2026, to ensure justice.

The judge ordered that the company, situated at Okhla Industrial Estate, Phase — III, New Delhi, cannot fire or punish the survivor while the case is ongoing, ensuring her livelihood is protected.

The company argued that the court had no power because she worked for a subsidiary. The judge rejected this, ruling that the parent company is responsible for the safety of all its employees.

The court took note of the "email blocking" and "office

Court protects female employee in POSH (sexual harassment) battle against renewable energy giant

RANJIT KUMAR SINHA
■ New Delhi

In a major win for workplace rights, a woman employee has secured a powerful court order protecting her job while she fights a sexual harassment case against a renewable energy giant.

The case, titled [Appellant Name X] vs. The New Delhi-based company and others, began when the victim filed a complaint on May 13, 2025, against a high-ranking official (the Head of Compliance).

She alleged several incidents of sexual harassment by the senior officials, including during a company event in May 2024, one of the officials — in an inebriated state — forcefully tried to outrage her modesty.

She also accused him of stalking and inappropriate touching. Crucially, she alleged caste-based bias, claiming his behaviour became more aggressive after he learned she was from a Scheduled Caste background.

After an internal inquiry concluded in November 2025, the company's committee found the official guilty of "unwelcome physical

contact." However, they only gave him a written warning and sent him on paid leave. The victim employee was further subjected to sexual harassment by the CEO of the company.

Meanwhile, the survivor alleged that she faced a "digital lockdown" in February 2026, when her office email was blocked, and was informed via text on March 6, 2026, not to come to the office. The survivor, through her advocate Apoorva Pandey, appealed and argued before the Industrial Tribunal at Rouse Avenue, and Judge Manjusha Wadhwa issued orders on March 12 and April 17, 2026, to ensure justice.

The judge ordered that the company, situated at Okhla Industrial Estate, Phase — III, New Delhi, cannot fire or punish the survivor while the case is ongoing, ensuring her livelihood is protected.

The company argued that the court had no power because she worked for a subsidiary. The judge rejected this, ruling that the parent company is responsible for the safety of all its employees.

The court took note of the "email blocking" and "office



barring," warning the company that such "shadow retaliation" would not be allowed.

In a parallel development, an FIR at Police Station Mehrauli, which invokes serious charges under Sections 75 (Sexual Harassment) and 78 (Stalking) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), was registered against the company and the two senior officials, and due to a lack of investigation, the victim employee approached the court for monitoring the investigation. Apoorva Pandey, counsel for the complainant (victim), argued that no investigation of the CEO has been done, and he has since left the country.

The case was listed before the Saket Mahila Court. Judicial Magistrate First Class Neetika Kapoor expressed sharp dissatisfaction with the police

investigation on April 17, 2026. Upon learning that the accused, who is the Global CEO of the company, had left the country, the court ordered the Assistant Commissioner of Police (ACP) to personally supervise the investigation and file a report.

The court noted that while the co-accused (Head of Compliance and Company Secretary) has joined the investigation, the lack of progress regarding the CEO necessitated high-level monitoring.

In the Rouse Avenue Tribunal, the case is directed against three primary respondents: the Company (Respondent No. 1), the Head of Secretarial and Global Compliance (Respondent No. 2/the accused), and the Global Chief Executive Officer, named in his capacity as the employer (Respondent No. 3). Additionally, the company's subsidiary has been impleaded to ensure the court's orders are fully enforceable.

Simultaneously, the criminal proceedings at Saket Mahila Court target the individuals involved in the alleged misconduct and subsequent intimidation.



Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited

Bu Shalimar Garden Plot No. C-18, Space No.4
Extension-II, Sahibabad, Ghaziabad UP-201005
SOL ID : 0931

IFSC : JAKA0SALIMR GSTIN: 09AAACT6167G1ZD (T) 0120-2648441

Email: salimr@jkbmail.com W: www.jkbank.com

Annexure IA POSSESSION NOTICE

Notice under Section 13 (4) of the SARFAESI Act, 2002 read with Rule 8 (1) of the Security (Enforcement) Interest Rules, 2002

Whereas Mr. Mohd Yaqoob Kaloo, as the Authorized Officer of the Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers under section 13(2) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notice dated 03.12.2025 thereby calling upon the Borrower namely **MR. KUNAL LAKHMI NARAYAN SINGH S/O LAKHMI NARAYAN SINGH R/O 53/4, FARM AREA, ROAD No 4, KADMA JAMSHEDPUR EAST, SINGHBHUM, JHARKHAND - 831005** to repay an amount of **Rs. 292.77,581.58 (Rupees Two Crore Ninety Two Lac Seventy Seven Thousand Five Hundred Eighty One and Fifty Eight Paise Only)** being the balance outstanding as on **30.11.2025** in the account of the Borrower, within 60 days from the date of the said notice together with the future interest and other charges thereon.

The said borrower having failed to repay the said amount, notice is hereby given to the said borrower in particular and the public in general that the undersigned being authorized officer of the J & K Bank Ltd. has taken possession of the mortgage property described herein below, in exercise of the powers conferred on me under section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules, on this **20th day of April, the year 2026**.

The said borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned against dealing with the said property in any manner whatsoever and any dealings with the said property will be subject to the charge of the J&K Bank Limited for the amount in aggregating to **Rs. 300,62,814.58 (Rupees Three Crore Twenty Sixty Two Thousand Eight Hundred Fourteen and Fifty Eight Paise only)** together with future interest thereon from **01.04.2026** and other charges incurred or to be incurred.

The borrowers attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of the Immovable Property

(As per the schedule provided in mortgage deed/latest particulars including any accreditations)

EQUITABLE MORTGAGE OF FREEHOLD RESIDENTIAL PROPERTY HAVING STILT + GF +3 STOREY BUILDING ALONG WITH UNDERNEATH LAND AREA OF 167.22 SQM BEARING NO RZ-661/A, F-BLOCK PHASE-I & II, 24A TO 25D, KHASRA NO 614, SITUATED AT VILLAGE NASIRPUR, SADH NAGAR-II, NEW DELHI-110045.

Date : 20.04.2026
Place : Azadpur, Delhi

Authorized Officer

Registered office Corporate Headquarters M.A. Road, Srinagar 190001 Kashmir, India T +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 F +91 (0)194 248 1928 CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048 E info@jkbmail.com W www.jkbank.net



Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited

BH Plaza A2/103, Sector-3, Rohini,
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POSSESSION NOTICE

Notice under Section 13 (4) of the SARFAESI Act, 2002 read with Rule 8 (1) of the Security (Enforcement) Interest Rules, 2002

Whereas the Authorized Officer of the Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers under section 13(2) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notice dated 14.01.2026 thereby calling upon the Borrower namely **Mrs. Nisha Ima**navil to repay an amount of **Rs. 28,15,231.78 (Rupees Twenty Eight Lakhs Fifteen Thousand Two Hundred Thirty One and Seventy Eight Paise Only)** being the balance outstanding as on 31.12.2025 in the account of the Borrower, within 60 days from the date of the said notice together with the future interest and other charges thereon.

The said borrower having failed to repay the said amount, notice is hereby given to the said borrower in particular and the public in general that the undersigned being authorized officer of the J & K Bank Ltd. has taken possession of the mortgage property described herein below, in exercise of the powers conferred on me under section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules, on this **17th day of April, the year 2026**.

The said borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned against dealing with the said property in any manner whatsoever and any dealings with the said property will be subject to the charge of the J&K Bank Limited for the amount in aggregating to **Rs. 27,73,894.78 (Rupees Twenty Seven Lakhs Seventy Three Thousand Eight Hundred Ninety Four and Paise Seventy Eight only)** together with future interest thereon from **01.03.2026** and other charges incurred or to be incurred.

The borrowers attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of the Immovable Property

(As per the schedule provided in mortgage deed/latest particulars including any accreditations)

Equitable Mortgage of Flat bearing built up property no. C-42, Second Floor without roof/terrace rights, area measuring 61.50 sq. yds. i.e 51.421 sq. mtrs. (15'x37') out of Kharsa no. 336/1 situated in the revenue estate of Village Bindapur, Delhi colony known as Subhash Park, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi-110059.

Bounded by East : Plot C-41, West : Portion of Plot No. C-42, North : Passage 20' South : Passage : 10'

Date : 20.04.2026
Place : Rohini

Authorized Officer

Registered office Corporate Headquarters M.A. Road, Srinagar 190001 Kashmir, India T +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 F +91 (0)194 248 1928 CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048 E info@jkbmail.com W www.jkbank.net



Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot

Ph: 01639-256232-256236

Advt. No.BFU-26/09

VACANCIES

Online applications are invited w.e.f 27-04-2026 to 17-05-2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e www.bfuhs.ac.in for the recruitment to the posts of Professor (Nursing)-02, Associate Professor (Nursing)-03, Assistant Professor (Nursing)-05 and Tutor/Demonstrator (Nursing)-07 under Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot.

For Application form, fee, specially wise detail of posts, Category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website: www.bfuhs.ac.in

Sd/-
REGISTRAR

3108/12/2026-27/10729 Dated CHD :- 22/04/2026

Date: 23th April, 2026 INVITATION TO THE STAKEHOLDER MEETING

DMRC is carrying out Environmental Studies for three new corridors and is pleased to invite the Stakeholders for a meeting as per the following schedule:

- 29th April : 9:00 am to 11:00 am, at Community Hall, Molar Band Ph-II,Near Mohan Estate Metro Station, New Delhi-76 and 2:00 pm to 4:00 pm, at Raja Ram Mohan Roy Memorial Hall, Near ITO Metro Station, New Delhi
- 30th April : 9:00 am to 11:00 am, at Hotel Tyche, Chuna Mandi, Paharganj, New Delhi and 2:00 pm to 4:00 pm, at Hotel Impress, Block 25, Vasant Kunj Rd, Block B, Mahipalpur, New Delhi



INDIAN BANK

Rajouri Garden, A-Block Branch, No. A-62, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi-110027 | Cont. No.: 011-25160727
E-mail: RajourigardenR547@indianbank.co.in

FOR PUBLIC NOTICE - LOST DOCUMENTS

I Bharat Kumar, S/o. S. Gurdev Singh, working as Branch Manager, Indian Bank having its branch at Rajouri Garden, A-Block, A-62, Rajouri Garden, New Delhi - 110027, hereby informs that:

1. Original Sale Deed Doc No. 13856, Addl. Book No. I, Vol. No. 10588, Pages 42-45, dated 19/09/2002, registered on 05/10/2002 in favour of Mr.Paramjeet Singh Bhandari and Smt.Raj Kaur.
2. Original GPA, agreement to sell, affidavit in favour of Mr.Satish Tayagi dated: 20/01/1990.

of property 32-A, out of Kharsa No. 8/17, situated in the area of Village Hastsal, Colony known as Shiv Vihar, New Delhi on which Bank has created registered mortgage is not traceable in the bank and therefore, declared lost. It is hereby advised not to deal with the said property in any manner thereby creating any title, right, interest whatsoever on the said property. Finder may please inform the bank at the above said address and mobile no. 9023573316.

Regards,
Branch Manager,
A-Block, Rajouri Garden



Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited

A-41/42, Palm Ext., Ramphal Chowk
Sector-07, Dwarka, New Delhi

POSSESSION NOTICE

Notice under Section 13 (4) of the SARFAESI Act, 2002 read with Rule 8 (1) of the Security (Enforcement) Interest Rules, 2002

Whereas as the Undersigned as Authorized Officer of the Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers under section 13(12) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notice under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 dated 10.01.2025 calling upon the Borrower/Mortgagors.

M/s Aarushi Home Sajawat : Radhey Shyam Chaturvedi (Proprietor)
S/o Bhanu Pratap Chaturvedi..... Borrower

Radhey Shyam Chaturvedi
S/o Bhanu Pratap Chaturvedi & Reeta Shyam..... Co-Borrower/Mortgagor

Present Address : Flat No 293-293, Near Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, Netaji Subash Apartment, Pocket-1, Sector 13,

Permanent Address : B-159, Mansa Ram Park, Uttam nagar, New Delhi-59 to repay an amount of **Rs. 35,29,667.07 (Rupees Thirty Five Lakhs Twenty Nine Thousand Six Hundred Sixty Seven and Paise Seven Only)** being the balance outstanding as on **31.10.2024** in the accounts of the Borrower, within 60 days from the date of the said notice together with the future interest and other charges thereon.

The said borrower having failed to repay the said amount, notice is hereby given to the said borrower in particular and the public in general that the undersigned being authorized officer of the J & K Bank Ltd. has taken possession of the mortgage property described herein below, in exercise of the powers conferred on me under section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules, on this **17th day of April, the year 2026**.

The said borrower, Guarantor cum Mortgagor in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned against dealing with the said property in any manner whatsoever and any dealings with the said property will be subject to the charge of the J&K Bank Limited for the amount in aggregating to **Rs. 31,29,991.48 (Rupees: Thirty One Lakhs Twenty Nine Thousand Nine Hundred Ninety One and Forty Eight Paise only)** together with future interest thereon from **01.04.2026** and other charges incurred or to be incurred.

The borrowers attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets which include (Hypothecated Stocks and Book-Debs) together with the right to transfer by way of lease, assignment or sale, without the intervention of the court.

Description of the Immovable Property

Primary Security :

Equitable Mortgage of Built Up 2 BHK flat bearing No 292-293, Fourth Floor with roof rights, area measuring 83.61 sq mts. Type - A, Pocket-1, Phase-1, Sector-13 Near Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, Netaji Subash Apartment (west facing), Dwarka New Delhi-110077. (Primary security in HLP and FITL loans)

Date : 17.04.2026
Place : Dwarka

Authorized Officer

Registered office Corporate Headquarters M.A. Road, Srinagar 190001 Kashmir, India T +91 (0)194 2481 930-35 F +91 (0)194 248 1928 CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048 E info@jkbmail.com W www.jkbank.net

Hindu Shree Foundation urges PM for Shankaracharya Study Centre in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On the auspicious occasion of the birth anniversary of Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya ji, the Hindu Shree Foundation has urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to establish a "Shankaracharya Study Centre" in the national Capital.

The foundation has also proposed the installation of a grand statue of the revered saint and a comprehensive museum to preserve and showcase the life, teachings, and legacy of the Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya ji.

In a letter to the Prime Minister, Hindu Shree Foundation's President Dr Shiv Chaudhary highlighted the need to promote and preserve India's Sanatan

knowledge tradition through structured academic and cultural initiatives. The proposed study centre on Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya would serve as a hub for research, education, and dissemination of teachings related to Advaita Vedanta and Indian philosophy, he said.

The Hindu Shree Foundation acknowledged the Narendra Modi government's efforts in promoting India's spiritual and cultural heritage, citing landmark initiatives such as the redevelopment of the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor and the transformation of Mahakaleshwar Temple. It also appreciated the installation of statues of Adi Shankaracharya at Omkareshwar Temple and Kedarnath Temple.

Emphasising the enduring relevance of Jagadguru Sri Adi Shankaracharya ji's teachings, the Foundation noted his pivotal role in revitalising Hindu philosophy and unifying the country through spiritual thought. "His contributions to Advaita Vedanta continue to inspire values of unity, harmony, and spiritual growth," said Dr Chaudhary.

The Hindu Shree Foundation is a registered charitable organisation working towards the preservation, restoration, and autonomy of India's temple traditions.



HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
APPENDIX- IV-A
(See proviso to rule 8 (6))

HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

Corporate Office at 167-169, 2nd Floor, Little Mount, Saidapet, Chennai – 600015. E-mail : auction@hindujahousingfinance.com

MR. PRAMOD CHAND - 99903 38759, MR. RAVI SHANKAR - 99997 35552, MR. RAKESH GUPTA- 98739 25255

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (hereinafter referred to as "the Act") read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 (hereinafter referred to as "the Rules"). Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below-described immovable property mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer of Hinduja Housing Finance Limited (Secured Creditor) having its Corporate Office at 167-169, 2nd Floor, Little Mount, Saidapet, Chennai – 600015 and one of its Branch Offices at Office No-210/211, Second Floor, Dashmesh Plaza, Sector-20B, NIT, Faridabad, Haryana-121001, will be sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is" and "Whatever there is" basis on the dates mentioned below for realization of the amount due to the Secured Creditor from the borrowers and guarantors. The sale will be done by the Authorized Officer through e-auction platform provided at the website: www.bankauctions.com

DATE OF INSPECTION OF PROPERTY : 04/05/2026 - 05/05/2026, 14:00 HRS - 17:00 HRS | EMD DEPOSIT LAST DATE: 08TH MAY, 2026 TILL 17:00 HRS. | DATE/TIME OF E-AUCTION: 09TH MAY, 2026 - 11:00 HRS-13:00 HRS.

LAN & Name of Borrower(s) / Co-Borrower(s)	Demand Notice Date & Amount: 05/07/2025 And Rs. 24,62,606/- as on 05.07.2025	Reserve Price Rs. 17,20,000/-	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) Rs. 1,72,000/-
Loan Account No. DL/DEL/PAND/A00002145			
1. Mr. Jagan Mehlawat (Borrower)	Date of Physical Possession: 06/01/2026	Total Outstanding as On Date 05/07/2025 Rs. 24,62,606/-	Bid Increase Amount Rs. 10000/-
2. Mrs. Hemlata Mehlawat (Co-Borrower)			

Description Of The Immovable Property/ Secured Asset: A Property/house/plot No. 1748, Type Lii/gf, (ground Floor), Area Measuring 35.25 Sq. Yards, Situated At Sector-29, Housing Board Colony Faridabad, Tehsil & District Faridabad Haryana. Bounded As Under:- East - House No.1749A, West- House No.1747A, North- Entry Road 16ft., South- Others Property

MODE OF PAYMENT:- ALL PAYMENT SHALL BE MADE BY DEMAND DRAFT IN FAVOUR OF HINDUJA HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED PAYABLE AT HARYANA.

Special Instructions/Caution:

Bidding in the last minutes/seconds should be avoided by the bidders in their own interest. Neither Hinduja Housing Finance Limited nor the Service Provider will be responsible for any lapses/failure (Internet failure, Power failure, etc.) on the part of the bidder in such cases. In order to ward off such contingent situation, bidders are requested to make all the necessary arrangements/alternatives such as back-up power supply and whatever else required so that they are able to circumvent such situation and are able to participate in the auction successfully.

TERMS & CONDITIONS OF ONLINE E-AUCTION SALE:-

1. The Property is being sold on "As is Where is", "As is What is", "Whatever there is" and "Without Recourse" basis. As such sale is without any kind of warranties & indemnities. 2. Particulars of the property/assets (viz. extent & measurements specified in the E-Auction Sale Notice has been stated to the best of the information of the Secured Creditor and Secured Creditor shall not be answerable for any error, mis-statement or omission. Actual extent & dimensions may differ. 3. E-Auction Sale Notice issued by the Secured Creditor is an invitation to the general public to submit their bids and the same does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation on the part of the Secured Creditor. Interested bidders are advised to peruse the title deeds with the Secured Creditor and to conduct own independent enquiries/due diligence about the title & present condition of the property/assets and claims/dues affecting the property before submission of bids. 4. Auction/bidding shall only be through "online electronic mode" through the website: auction@hindujahousingfinance.com and <https://www.bankauctions.com> Or Auction provided by the service provider C1 India PVT LTD, who shall arrange & coordinate the entire process of auction through the e-auction platform. 5. The bidders may participate in e-auction for bidding from their place of choice. Internet connectivity shall have to be ensured by bidder himself. Secured Creditor/service provider shall not be held responsible for the internet connectivity, network problems, own system crash, power failure etc. 6. For details, help, procedure and online bidding on e-auction prospective bidders may contact the Service Provider C1 India PVT LTD. 605A, Add: C1 India PVT LTD, 3rd Floor, Plot No.68 sector-44, Gurgaon, Haryana-122003. (Contact Person: Mitalesh Kumar, Phone No. 7608044466, Email: delhi@c1india.com , Support Mobile Number:-7291981124/1125/1126). 7. For participating in the e-auction sale the intending bidders should register their name at www.bankauctions.com and auction@hindujahousingfinance.com well in advance and shall get the user id and password. Intending bidders are advised to change only the password immediately upon receiving it from the service provider. 8. For participating in e-auction, intending bidders have to deposit a refundable Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) i.e. 10% OF RESERVE PRICE (as mentioned above) shall be payable by interested bidders through Demand Draft in favor of "Hinduja Housing Finance Limited". 9. The intending bidders should submit the duly filled in Bid Form (format available on <https://www.bankauctions.com>) and pramod.chand@hindujahousingfinance.com along with the Demand Draft remittance towards EMD in a sealed cover addressed to the Authorized Officer at Hinduja Housing Finance Limited, at Office No-286, 2nd Floor, Pocket-1, Sector-25, Rohini, New Delhi-110085. 10. The sealed cover should be super scribed with "Bid for participating in E-Auction Sale in the Loan Account Number (as mentioned above) for the property (as mentioned above). After expiry of the last date of submission of bids with EMD, Authorized Officer shall examine the bids received by him and confirm the details of the qualified bidders (who have quoted their bids over and above the reserve price and paid the specified EMD with the Secured Creditor) to the service provider C1 India PVT LTD to enable them to allow only those bidders to participate in the online inter-se bidding/auction proceedings at the date and time mentioned in E-Auction Sale Notice. 11. Inter-se bidding among the qualified bidders shall start from the highest bid quoted by the qualified bidders. During the process of inter-se bidding, there will be unlimited extension of "10" minutes each, i.e. the end time of e-auction shall be automatically extended by 10 Minutes each time if bid is made within 10 minutes from the last extension. 12. Bids once made shall not be cancelled or withdrawn. All bids made from the user id given to bidder will be deemed to have been made by him alone. 13. Immediately upon closure of E-Auction proceedings, the highest bidder shall confirm the final amount of bid quoted by him by E-Mail both to the Authorized Officer on his mail id pramod.chand@hindujahousingfinance.com and the Service Provider for getting declared as successful bidder in the E-Auction Sale proceedings. 14. The successful bidder shall immediately i.e. on the same day or not later than next working day, as the case may be, pay a deposit of twenty five per cent, of the amount of the sale price, which is inclusive of earnest money deposited, if any, to the Authorized Officer conducting the sale. The balance amount of purchase price payable shall be on or before fifteenth day of confirmation of sale of the immovable property. 15. In case of default in payment of above stipulated amounts by the successful bidder/auction purchaser within the stipulated time, the sale will be cancelled and the amount already paid (including EMD) will be forfeited and the property will be again put for sale. 16. At the expiry of the successful bidder, the Authorized Officer in his (its) capacity shall grant further time for writing, for depositing the balance of the bid amount. 17. The Successful Bidder shall pay applicable TDS (or sale proceeds) on the sum of the purchase price to the Authorized Officer. 18. The Municipal charges/Taxes, Electricity dues (if any) and any other authorities dues (if any) has to be paid by the successful bidder before issuance of the sale certificate. Bids shall be made taking into consideration of all the statutory dues pertaining to the property. 19. Sale Certificate will be issued by the Authorized Officer in favour of the successful bidder only upon deposit of entire purchase price/bid amount and furnishing the necessary proof in respect of payment of all taxes/charges. 20. Applicable legal charges for conveyance, stamp duty, registration charges and other incidental charges shall be borne by the auction purchaser. 21. The Authorized officer may postpone/cancel the E-Auction Sale proceedings without assigning any reason whatsoever. In case the E-Auction Sale scheduled is postponed to a later date before 15 days from the scheduled date of sale, it will be displayed on the website of the service provider. 22. The decision of the Authorized Officer is final, binding and unquestionable. 23. All bidders who submitted the bids, shall be deemed to have read and understood the terms and conditions of the E-Auction Sale and be bound by them. 24. For further details and queries, please contact Authorized Officer, Mr. Pramod Chand, Mobile No. 9990338759, Mr. Ravi Shankar, Mob: 9999735552, Mr. Rakesh Gupta, Mob: 9873925255 at branch office at Hinduja Housing Finance Limited, at Office No-210/211, Second Floor, Dashmesh Plaza, Sector-20B, NIT, Faridabad, Haryana-121001. 25. This is also a 15 days notice in E-auction of the above said loan account pursuant to rule 8(6) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, about holding of auction sale on the above-mentioned date/place.

Place: Haryana. Date : 23/04/2026.

Sd/- Authorized Officer - Hinduja Housing Finance Limited

CM launches water ATMs in Shalimar Bagh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Wednesday inaugurated a network of water ATMs in Shalimar Bagh, aimed at improving access to safe drinking water in densely populated areas of the Capital.

The facilities, equipped with five-stage RO systems, can supply up to 2,000 litres of purified water per hour. Officials said the initiative is designed to provide affordable and reliable drinking water to residents, especially in areas facing supply challenges.

The Chief Minister said ensuring clean drinking water for every household remains a key priority.

"These water ATMs are an important step towards making safe water accessible to all," she said while inter-



acting with residents.

The units have been installed at multiple locations, including the AU Block at Ekta Camp in Pitampura, Som Bazar Road in Haiderpur, AA Seva Basti near Fortis Hospital, and CA Block Seva Basti. During the visit, the Chief Minister also distributed water ATM cards to local residents to enable easy access to the service.

Officials said the system will help reduce dependence

on irregular water supply and improve overall public health standards in high-density neighbourhoods.

Highlighting broader efforts, the Chief Minister said the Government has planned large-scale upgrades to the city's water infrastructure. Nearly ₹9,000 crore has been allocated for laying new pipelines, replacing old networks, and strengthening distribution systems.

She also inspected ongoing development work on Som Bazar Road in Haiderpur, where road construction and related civic works are underway. Officials briefed her on the progress of projects being carried out by the Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board and other agencies.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister directed officials to speed up construction work while maintaining quality standards.

She stressed the need to minimise inconvenience to residents and ensure proper traffic management at work sites.

The Chief Minister also emphasised cleanliness and safety during construction. She said strict adherence to safety norms and proper site management must be ensured at all times. Later, the Chief Minister visited the

CA Block to review the cleaning work of the Munak Canal and inspect the construction of a Chhath ghat. She sought updates from officials and issued directions for the timely completion of both projects.

Officials were told to ensure that the work meets quality standards and is completed within the set timeline. The Chief Minister said the projects must be ready well before Chhath Puja to avoid inconvenience to devotees.

She noted that proper infrastructure for religious and cultural events is an important responsibility of the government. Clean and well-maintained facilities are essential for public convenience and safety, she added.

The Chief Minister said the government is working with a focus on improving basic services across the city.

Parvesh Verma inaugurates drainage, road, water projects in West Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Wednesday inaugurated a series of infrastructure projects in Palam and Nilothi to improve drainage, road connectivity, and water supply in key residential areas.

The projects include strengthening the Palam Link Drain embankments, constructing four box-culvert bridges in Palam, and upgrading connectivity near Nilothi. Officials said the works are designed to address long-standing civic issues such as waterlogging, traffic congestion, and gaps in basic services.

A major component of the initiative is an ₹8 crore project by the Delhi Jal Board to lay



new water and sewer lines in Mahavir Enclave, Ramphal Chowk, Madhu Vihar, and Sadh Nagar. These areas have faced persistent problems related to water supply and sanitation.

Speaking at the inauguration, Verma said the focus of the government is on solving everyday problems faced by residents. "Development is about addressing real issues

on the ground. These projects will bring visible improvement in daily life," he said. He added that better drainage systems will help reduce flooding during the monsoon, while improved road infrastructure will ease movement in congested areas.

"These works will directly benefit thousands of families by improving basic services and connectivity," he said.

Govt plans bus route overhaul, seeks staff input

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh has called for direct inputs from drivers, conductors, and depot managers to improve last-mile connectivity, as the Government pushes ahead with a major overhaul of bus routes and expansion of electric mobility.

The direction came during a review meeting of the Transport Department, where the minister stressed that ground-level feedback is essential for making the public transport system more efficient and accessible. "The route rationalisation exercise must reflect real conditions on the ground. Inputs from DTC staff will help improve connectivity and passenger experience," Singh said.

The government is currently undertaking a com-



prehensive route rationalisation study for 9-metre DEVI electric buses.

The study is being carried out by the Indian Institute of Technology Delhi under an agreement with the Delhi Transport Infrastructure Development Corporation. Officials said the study aims to redesign Delhi's bus network using data-driven methods. It covers 121 routes in the East Zone, 181 in the West Zone, and 194 in the North Zone. Work for the South Zone is also in progress.

The minister said that incorporating practical insights from transport staff will ensure that routes are better aligned with commuter needs. He added that improving connectivity will encourage more people to use public transport, which will help reduce congestion and pollution.

Singh also reviewed the progress of interstate electric bus services operated by the Delhi Transport Corporation. These services have received a positive response from passengers,

according to officials.

At present, electric buses are running on routes connecting Delhi with Baraut and Ghaziabad in Uttar Pradesh, and Sonapat, Dharuhera, and Panipat in Haryana. The government now plans to expand services to additional routes.

Proposed new routes include Delhi to Rewari, Karnal, Alwar, and Jewar. Officials said the expansion is part of a broader plan to promote clean mobility beyond the capital.

The minister said the response to electric buses shows growing acceptance of eco-friendly transport options. He added that the government remains committed to strengthening sustainable transport systems.

In another initiative, the Transport Department is exploring the introduction of bus services to major religious destinations.

SC sets aside Delhi HC verdict asking Centre to vacate residential premises at Sujan Singh Park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court (SC) on Wednesday set aside a Delhi High Court verdict asking the Centre to evict residential premises at the posh Sujan Singh Park in the national Capital.

Setting aside the High Court verdict, a bench comprising justices Sanjay Karol and Prashant Kumar Mishra held that the Central Government's occupation of residential premises at Sujan Singh Park is not governed by the DRC (Delhi Rent Control) Act but is instead regulated exclusively by the terms of a Government grant dating back to 1945.

It also upheld the supremacy of the Government Grants Act, 1895, over the Delhi Rent Control Act of 1958 in the present case.

"In view of our categorical finding that the DRC Act has no manner of application to the present lis, the very foundation upon which the learned ARC (Additional Rent Controller) assumed jurisdiction to entertain the eviction suit by the respondent stands eroded.

"The eviction proceedings, having been instituted, entertained and decided under a statutory regime alien to the legal character of the relationship between the parties, are thus vitiated at their inception. The High Court, in affirming the said course on the premise that the respondent would otherwise be left without a remedy, with respect, misdirected itself," Justice Mishra, who authored the verdict, said.

The existence or absence of a remedy cannot determine



jurisdiction, and equally, in the absence of any express stipulation in the lease deed providing for eviction on account of non-payment of rent, no such right can be inferred, the verdict said.

It said the premises occupied by the government under a perpetual lease deed originating as a "Government Grant" are governed exclusively by the terms of that grant.

Consequently, such

arrangements are immune to the provisions of the DRC Act, it added.

The case dates back to a perpetual lease deed executed on April 26, 1945, by the Governor General in Council in favour of Sir Sobha Singh and Sons Pvt Ltd.

The lease concerned 7.58 acres of land for the construction of approximately 100 residential flats. Under a clause of the allotment letter, the central government reserved the right to have 50 per cent of the flats leased to its officials at a "fair rent".

Over time, the government occupied several flats, servant quarters, and garages. In 1991, respondent Sir Sobha Singh and Sons filed an eviction petition alleging the Government had defaulted on rent payments between 1989 and 1991.



Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs
Government of India



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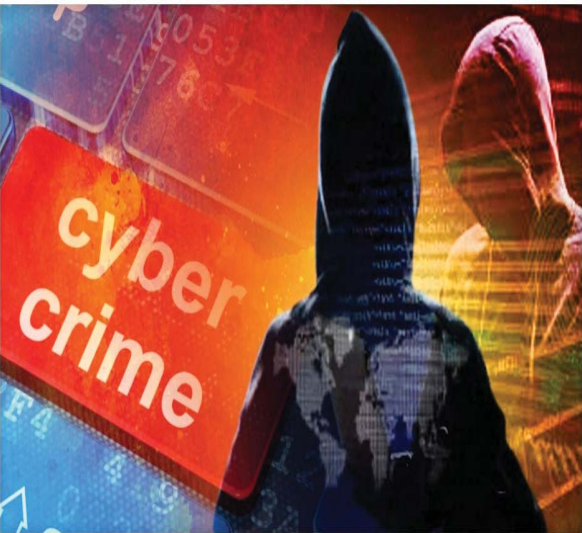
Artists perform during the offering of Long-life Prayers to the Tibetan spiritual leader Dalai Lama, unseen, by Dhasa Dhotoe Welfare Society and Lodrik Welfare Association at the Main Tibetan Temple (Tsulaglakhang) in Dharamshala, Himachal Pradesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Eight persons have been arrested from different parts of Gujarat for their alleged involvement in a cyber fraud network involving transactions worth more than ₹288 crore, the State CID Crime said on Wednesday.

The accused were apprehended from multiple locations in different cities, including Surat, Rajkot, Bhavnagar and Unjha, over several days as part of “Operation Mule Hunt 2.0”, a special drive launched to crack down on organised cyber crime networks, the Cyber Centre of Excellence of the CID Crime said in a statement.

A mule account is a bank account used by criminals to receive, transfer, or launder illicit funds with or without the knowledge of its holder. According to the statement,



the accused were involved in opening and operating mule bank accounts in the names of different individuals and firms to facilitate the transfer of funds obtained through various cyber frauds.

These illicit funds were subsequently converted into cash and routed through hawala (illegal money transfer system) and ‘angadia’ (traditional courier) channels to conceal their origin,

the CID Crime stated.

The Cyber Centre of Excellence said the wide-spread operation led to the detection of cyber crime networks handling more than ₹288 crore. Teams carried out searches in Surat, Bhavnagar, Rajkot and Unjha, leading to the arrest of the eight accused allegedly linked to multiple cyber fraud cases registered across the country.

The accused were identified by police as Mukesh Mer, Faridkhan Nasirkhan Pathan, Akshay Patel, Devendra Patel, Chetan Naranbhai Amalani, Jatin Kakkad, Kapilbhai Kotak, Mahendra Kokiya.

Investigations said the accused knowingly allowed their bank accounts to be used for illegal financial transactions in exchange for commissions. They either opened accounts in their

own names or procured accounts of others, which were then used to park and transfer proceeds of cyber crimes while masking the identity of the actual perpetrators, they alleged.

The statement said the accused played a crucial role in enabling different types of cyber crimes, including online financial scams, internet banking and UPI-related frauds, investment rackets and deposit-related frauds.

In the cases linked to Surat and Bhavnagar, the accused were found connected to 181 cyber fraud complaints registered across the country, with 81 FIRs lodged in various states.

The fraud amount in these cases alone was estimated to be over ₹174 crore, officials said.

Police said they have seized mobile phones and a laptop from the accused,

which contained details of numerous firms, identity documents of several individuals and a large number of fake invoices, indicating a well-organised crime network was duping people.

In another case from Unjha (Mahesana district), the accused were linked to 125 cyber fraud complaints involving transactions of more than ₹114 crore, as per data available on national cyber crime reporting platforms. Similarly, arrests made in Rajkot were connected to 26 cyber fraud complaints and an FIR involving fraud worth ₹59.79 lakh, the statement added.

In the last one month alone, 40 people have been arrested in Gujarat in connection with 1,039 cyber fraud complaints involving a total fraud amount of ₹ 622 crore under ‘Operation Mule Hunt 2.0’, it added.

Industrial accidents: 3 workers die daily; safety norms are ignored

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

A disturbing trend in industrial safety has come to light, with an average of three workers losing their lives every day in factory-related accidents across India, raising serious concerns over workplace safety standards.

According to data from the Directorate General Factory Advice Service and Labour Institutes (DGFSLI), only about 10 per cent of factories in the country have implemented formal safety policies. Even more alarming is the fact that safety officers are present in merely 2 per cent of these establishments. The issue has gained



urgency following two recent factory accidents in the past 15 days that claimed 49 workers’ lives, prompting renewed scrutiny of industrial conditions and enforcement mechanisms.

As per official data available up to 2023, India has 3,34,000 registered factories employing over 19.1 million workers.

BJP intensifies preparations for PM’s conference on women

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Varanasi

Preparations have intensified in Varanasi ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s proposed visit to the city on April 28, with the BJP and its Mahila Morcha stepping up efforts.

BJP’s Kashi region president Dilip Patel said the party’s district and city units have planned a booth-level outreach campaign to make a proposed women’s conference during Modi’s visit historic. Patel said the prime minister will arrive in Varanasi on the afternoon of April 28 and inaugurate projects worth crores at the Banaras Locomotive Works.

He will then address the massive women’s conference and stay overnight in the city. On April 29, Modi will inaugurate the Rinpoché Sangpa Hospital and Medical College of the Central Institute of Higher Tibetan Studies and later, leave for Haridwar to inaugurate the Ganga Expressway.

Patel said since 2014, the prime minister has taken several historic steps to promote women’s empower-



BJP Mahila Morcha activists raising slogans during a protest against the opposition in Varanasi

ment, self-reliance and their participation in social and political spheres.

He appealed to women to participate in the upcoming event in large numbers, saying the conference would send a strong message of women’s empowerment across the country. To ensure the participation of more than 50,000 women, responsibilities have been assigned to senior leaders across all eight Assembly segments in this

Uttar Pradesh district. According to the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), meetings at the mandal level have been completed and Mahila Morcha teams will now carry out a door-to-door outreach campaign to invite women to participate in the conference.

The BJP aims to make the event historic, with the organisation mobilising its full strength for the programme, Patel added.

FROM PAGE - 1

Trump extends ceasefire, as peace talks remain...

The United States must end its blockade on Iran as a prerequisite for any further ceasefire talks in Islamabad, an Iranian diplomat said Wednesday. Mojtaba Ferdousi Pour, the head of the Iranian mission in Egypt, told *The Associated Press* that communications with Pakistani mediators are underway “to implement Iran’s conditions”.

“We won’t negotiate under threat,” he said. “We won’t go to Islamabad before the lifting of the blockade.” He accused the US of using the ceasefire to build up more forces for a possible resumption of military action against the Islamic Republic. “Behind the scenes, they say something, but in public, they say and do something else,” he said.

An independent Islamabad-based analyst, Syed Mohammad Ali, says President Donald Trump has apparently concluded that a blockade of Iranian ports is a more effective way to pressure Iran’s already fragile economy than the continued use of force.

“As far as Trump’s war strategy is concerned, this blockade appears to be less expensive and more effective,” he said Wednesday. Ali said prospects for a second round of talks between the United States and Iran have not faded, as Pakistan, with support from regional countries, continues efforts to prevent the collapse of negotiations.

He said securing an extension of the ceasefire for an indefinite period from Trump is an achievement for Pakistan. Pakistan’s top political and military leadership has worked to prevent talks from collapsing and to persuade the US to extend the ceasefire over the past 24 hours, officials said Wednesday.

Two Pakistani officials told *The Associated Press* that authorities will keep security arrangements in place in Islamabad in case US and Iranian delegations ultimately arrive.

Pakistan is also still waiting to hear from Tehran on when it will send a delegation for a second round, the officials said, speaking on condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to talk to the media.

In Islamabad, police and troops remained on alert along key roads, manning checkpoints.

Residents were forced to take longer routes as authorities restricted access to parts of the city. “We have not received any instructions to remove these barricades,” said police officer Mohammad Aslam as he directed commuters to turn back and use alternative routes.

SC slams Mamata for meddling in ED raid

“But none of them would have ever conceived of a situation that in this country, a day will come when a sitting chief minister will walk into the office...,” Justice Mishra said.

Guruswamy said, “I am on the maintainability.... There was no misconduct, there was no

intimidation to any officer.” The bench did not agree with the submissions that the questions raised in the matter should be referred to a larger bench. “We will decide whether an Article-32 petition in maintainable or not. What is the substantial question of law which requires consideration by a five-judge bench?” it asked. While observing that it is not hearing an appeal, the bench said there would be some questions of law involved in all the pleas filed before it but that does not mean that every Article-32 petition should be referred to a five-judge bench.

The bench also heard the submissions advanced by senior advocate Siddharth Luthra, who appeared in the court for one of the respondents. “This is an extraordinary situation. Before the other bench where the SIR (Special Intensive Revision of the electoral roll) is under question, we have seen the situation where several judicial officers were kept hostage. Now, you want that the petitioners (the ED and its officials) should have gone to a magistrate with a section-200 (CrPC) complaint?” the bench asked. “We cannot shut our eyes from the reality of what is happening. We cannot lose sight of the practical situation which is present at the spot in the state,” Justice Mishra observed. The judge further said it is not litigation between Ram and Shyam as this is an extraordinary situation where the contours are totally different. The hearing in the matter remained inconclusive and would continue on Thursday.

Iran seizes India-bound ship in Strait of Hormuz

The vessels - identified as MSC Francesca and Epaminondas - were reportedly taken into custody by Iran’s elite Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC).

Iranian state television confirmed that both ships were being escorted to Iranian waters.

According to marine traffic data, Epaminondas, a Liberian-flagged container ship, was en route to Mundra Port in Gujarat’s Kachch district when it was intercepted. Its navigational status was subsequently listed as “stopped,” raising concerns over the safety of cargo and crew.

The seizures come days after a tense maritime incident in which Iranian forces reportedly opened fire on an India-bound vessel attempting to transit the narrow chokepoint, forcing it to turn back abruptly. The Strait of Hormuz, through which a significant portion of the world’s oil supply passes, has become a flashpoint amid deteriorating relations between Washington and Tehran.

The latest move signals a hardening of Iran’s posture following earlier diplomatic engagements with the Trump administration that failed to yield de-escalation.

The incident also comes despite a ceasefire reportedly facilitated by Pakistan earlier in the day. While the agreement briefly raised hopes of easing tensions, the situation in and around the Strait remains volatile.

Analysts point to continued US maritime restrictions and enforcement measures, alongside aggressive patrolling by the IRGC Navy,

as factors contributing to the fragile security environment in the region.

The interception of a Gujarat-bound vessel is likely to raise alarm in India, given the country’s heavy reliance on maritime trade routes passing through the Strait of Hormuz. Any prolonged disruption could impact supply chains, particularly in the energy sector.

Authorities are closely monitoring developments, though there has been no immediate official response from the ship owners or concerned Governments at the time of publication.

Citizen is god: PM writes to officials

He said the atmosphere is filled with the enthusiasm of Rongali Bihu, Vishu, Puthandu, Poila Boishakh, Maha Bishuba Pana Sankranti and Baisakhi. Modi said these festivals are about hope, renewal and new beginnings.

“At such a time, you have become a part of a festival of learning and growing — the *Sadhana Saptah*. I congratulate you for being a part of this unique effort that brings together civil servants across the length and breadth of India,” he said.

The Prime Minister said he would like to express his deepest appreciation for the civil servants’ passion for service, which enabled them to be a part of this effort.

He said it reflected an unwavering faith, remarkable spirit and unparalleled dedication to strengthening the journey towards a ‘Viksit Bharat’. “I have always believed that such platforms are essential for personal growth and for enhancing our professional capacities,” he said.

Modi said discovering something new is among the finest things in life, and one has to keep that spirit of enquiry alive. “It is with this principle that we launched Mission Karmayogi. Yes, on one hand, it was about training and learning new things.

“But, at the same time, it was a reaffirmation that a Government must serve the citizens to the best of its abilities, that governance must be grounded in compassion and that those who bear the responsibility of public service must themselves be the finest examples of lifelong learning,” he said. The Prime Minister said all civil servants must remember that earlier the yardstick was to be better than the past, but now, it should be to evaluate all the efforts based on the aim of creating a developed nation by 2047.

“The speed, scale, direction and intensity of our efforts must be guided by this vision...The principle of ‘Nagrikdevo Bhava’ must be at the heart of every decision,” he said.

Modi said the iGOT Karmayogi platform, on which the civil servants are learning now, is India’s largest and most ambitious effort to “transform the human capital of our Government and you are at its core.”

“I was told that the three objectives of Sadhana Saptah were: becoming tech ready, understanding our traditions and achieving tangible outcomes grounded in citizen centricity,” he said.

The prime minister said these are indeed

noble principles and when these threads are woven into a single fabric, governance becomes modern, rooted in culture and firmly rooted in ‘Jana Seva’.

“I have experienced that commitment to continuous learning is a source of positive energy. I am sure you will agree that we live in an era where keeping oneself updated and upskilled is no longer optional,” he said, adding that committing to constant learning is the only way to be ahead of the curve.

“Over a period of one week, your zeal and Sadhana have been commendable. I am confident that this collective learning movement has ignited a new energy within our civil services. What has made me very happy is the scale of Sadhana Saptah 2026,” he said.

During Sadhana (Strengthening Adaptive Development and Humane Aptitude for National Advancement) Saptah (April 2-8), civil servants across the country participated in structured capacity-building programmes designed to build competencies required for achieving the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047.

The Prime Minister said it is a delight to see this being marked on an unprecedented scale of engagement, recording over 3.1 crore course completions by over 46 lakh learners, of whom about 33.4 lakh learners completed more than four hours of learning.

“I urge you to continue breaking the silos within your departments. We must move away from the old mindset of working in isolation and embrace a ‘whole-of-Government’ approach,” he said. Remember, Modi said, the progress of India is the sum of the collective victories across every state and every department.

“Let the spirit of team building you practised this week become the permanent culture of your office. Use the digital tools and data-driven insights you have explored to make governance more efficient and citizen-centric. My best wishes for your journey ahead,” he said.

Ex-help arrested in brutal south Delhi...

CCTV footage and eyewitness accounts have confirmed his movement. Two separate video clips show him approaching the house at 6:30 am and leaving the area at 7:22 am.

Police said the accused was familiar with the house layout. He knew the exact location where the spare key was usually kept for the family’s maid. Using that key, Rahul opened the gate and entered the premises. There were no signs of forced entry. “We have strong evidence against him,” the Joint CP said. “The accused changed his clothes after committing the crime. We have evidence of that as well.”

Rahul allegedly entered the house when the officer’s family had gone for their daily gym session. Police claim, he was aware of this routine, which he had observed during his time working with the family. They believe Rahul planned the crime based on this knowledge. After entering the house, he allegedly raped and strangled the officer’s daughter, stole around Rs 2 lakh in cash, changed his clothes, and fled from the spot.

The victim was found lying on the floor

FOWA hosts awareness event on Earth Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The Forest Officers Wives Association (FOWA) organised a grand and inspiring programme on the occasion of Earth Day 2026, aimed at promoting environmental conservation and awareness.

The event witnessed enthusiastic participation from members, children, and invited guests, creating an atmosphere of collective responsibility towards protecting the planet.

The programme commenced with a warm welcome to the guests, followed by the ceremonial lighting of the lamp. Vishakha Verma delivered the welcome address, highlighting the significance of



Earth Day and the importance of community participation in safeguarding the environment.

A felicitation ceremony was held to honour the distinguished guests, who also shared their insightful thoughts on the theme of Earth Day. They emphasised the importance of sustainable development, environmental protection, and individual responsibility in preserving natural resources for future generations.

Nitin Gadkari stresses multi-fuel strategy at Green Transport Conclave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari on Tuesday said the transport sector remains one of the largest contributors to carbon emissions, necessitating urgent and coordinated efforts to transition towards sustainable mobility.

Addressing the inaugural ceremony of the two-day Green Transport Conclave: Accelerating Towards the Future of Sustainable and Green Mobility in the national Capital, Gadkari highlighted that India currently imports nearly 87 per cent of its energy requirements, underlining the urgent need to achieve energy self-reliance.

He emphasised that no single technology — electric vehicles, hydrogen, or flex-fuel — can independently meet India's growing energy demand, advocating for a balanced, multi-fuel approach.

The conclave was organised by the Indian Federation of Green Energy (IFGE), with the support of the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, Government of India. Manoj Kumar Singh, CEO, UP State Transformation Commission (STC), attended



as the Guest of Honour in the inaugural session. Eminent speakers who addressed included top officers and other stakeholders from Road Transport, Aviation, Railways and Marine sectors.

The Pioneer, Aviation World, and Bharat Energy Compass were the media partners. IFGE is a leading industry body committed to promoting renewable energy and sustainable mobility through policy advocacy, industry collaboration, and knowledge exchange platforms.

Manoj Kumar Singh emphasised that India's transport strategy is evolving beyond electrification towards a multi-fuel and multi-modal ecosystem. He highlighted the integration of EVs, biofuels, sustainable aviation fuels, and green logistics, along with the need to

align road transport with logistics corridors and clean energy infrastructure to create a resilient and future-ready mobility framework.

The conclave enabled extensive deliberations on critical areas, including enabling policy frameworks at both central and state levels for low-carbon transport; advancement of sustainable urban mobility through electric vehicles and biofuels; decarbonisation of long-haul, intercity, and rural transport across road, rail, and aviation sectors; promotion of efficient and sustainable freight movement via road, maritime, and rail networks; and the integration of advanced technologies such as automation, artificial intelligence, system integration, and fuel dispensing infrastructure in the transport ecosystem.

A significant highlight of the

inaugural session was the signing of a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between CSIR-Central Road Research Institute and the Indian Federation of Green Energy (IFGE).

The eminent speakers addressed the conclave, including Sanjay Bandoopathyaya (IAS Retd), Chairman, Green Transport & Mobility Committee, IFGE, former Chairman Inland Waterway Authority of India; R Srinivas, Hony.

Secretary, IUT and Former Town & Country Planner, TCPO/MoHUA and Visiting Faculty, School of Planning and Architecture, New Delhi; Mahmood Ahmad, Addl. Secretary, Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, Government of India; Rajnath Ram, Advisor (Energy), NITI Aayog; Joshua Wycliffe, Director — Advocacy & Communications, Global Biofuels Alliance; Ajay Jha, Director (Environment and Housekeeping Management), Railway Board, Ministry of Railways; Dr Virinder Sharma, Member (Technical), Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM); Vaibhav Dange, Founder Director, IFGE and Sanjay Ganjoo, Director General, IFGE amongst others.

Vice President slams Kharge over terrorist remark against PM Modi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bidar (Karnataka)

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Wednesday took a veiled dig at AICC President Mallikarjun Kharge over his remark against Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha "fails to distinguish between terror and those who fight it."

He made the remark at the beginning of his speech at the Amrit Mahotsava (75th birth anniversary) celebration of Dr Basavalinga Pattadevaru Mahaswamiji of Hiremath Samsthan at Sri Channabasavashram in Bhalki, Bidar district.

Kharge, Governor Thaawarchand Gehlot, and Minister Eshwar Khandre were among those present at the event. "I had a slight difference with Kharge ji-only a difference in vision. Sometimes, I feel Kharge ji does not differentiate between black and white, or between a terrorist and the terror to the terrorist. Otherwise, I have no problem; he is a very good friend of mine," Radhakrishnan said. Kharge on Tuesday accused



Prime Minister Modi of "terrorising" political parties by misusing Government machinery and central agencies to stifle the Opposition, triggering strong reactions from the BJP, which criticised the Opposition leader for calling Modi a "terrorist."

Addressing a press conference in Chennai alongside AICC General Secretary (Organisation) KC Venugopal, Kharge initially referred to the Prime Minister as a "terrorist" while criticising the AIADMK's alliance with the BJP.

Questioning how the AIADMK-a party rooted in the Dravidian ideologies of Periyar and CN Annadurai-could justify partnering with Modi, Kharge said: "How can these AIADMK leaders, who themselves display the photo of Annadurai, align with Modi? He is a terrorist... He does not believe in equality. His party does not believe in equality and justice.

CEC in cahoots with BJP for Bengal win, alleges Kapil Sibal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

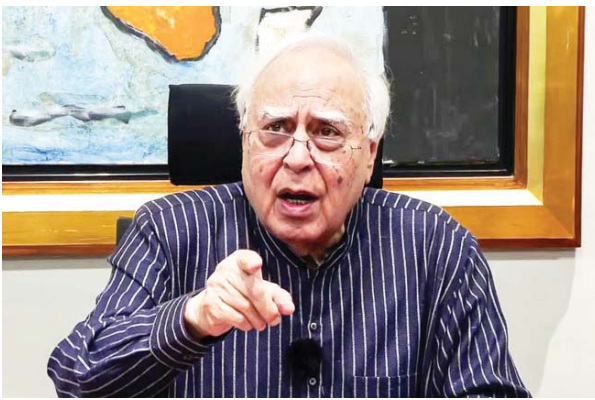
Former law minister Kapil Sibal on Wednesday accused Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar of working in cahoots with the BJP to make the party win the West Bengal elections, saying he is a "national shame" and it is his "vocation" to make sure that the BJP emerges victorious.

The Independent Rajya Sabha MP also came down heavily on the BJP-led Centre

and the Election Commission of India (ECI) over the massive deployment of security personnel for the Bengal polls to be held in two phases on April 23 and 29.

Questioning the use of the logical discrepancy argument for "disenfranchising" people in Bengal, Sibal said, "They did not use this in Maharashtra and Haryana but are using it in West Bengal."

It is the chief election commissioner who is the "logical



discrepancy" in this country, Sibal said, adding that nothing that the top poll official says is "logical".

"His discrepancy is stamped all over West Bengal. It is a shame that we have an election commissioner of this nature. It is an absolute national shame. It is also a national shame that nobody is doing anything about it," Sibal said.

Accusing Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar of being in cahoots

with the BJP, Sibal said the CEC's "vocation" is to make sure that the BJP somehow wins the election in West Bengal.

Taking a dig at Yogi Adityanath for reportedly attributing a quote by Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose to Swami Vivekanand, Sibal said the Uttar Pradesh chief minister has no idea about history and the Constitution, as he only knows about bulldozers and other such things.

Professor Rama Shanker Dubey appointed Chancellor of NIEPA



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Vice-Chancellor of the Central University of Gujarat, Professor Rama Shanker Dubey, has been appointed as the Chancellor of the National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration (NIEPA), New Delhi.

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan has appointed him to the position for a period of five years with immediate effect.

Necessary orders in this regard have been issued by the Ministry of Education. Notably, Professor Dubey has previously served as Vice-Chancellor of Tilka Manji Bhagalpur University, Bihar, and Guru Ghasidas University, Bilaspur, in addition to his tenure at the Central University of Gujarat.

Census 2027: 26 lakh families opt for self-enumeration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Over 26 lakh households have already availed the self-enumeration facility during the first phase of the Census operations underway in various States and Union territories, the Registrar General of India (RGI) said on Wednesday.

In a social media message, the RGI said the numbers indicate growing participation in the digital initiative for Census 2027.

"By choosing to provide their details online, these families have embraced a faster, smarter and more convenient way to contribute to nation-building. The #SelfEnumeration facility for Phase 1 - Houselisting and Housing Census (HLO) is currently underway in select States/UTs," the RGI said.



The Census, which is the eighth since independence, is being conducted in two phases - the first stage is known as house listing and housing Census, and the second is the popula-

tion Census.

Field visits for the housing listing and housing census began on April 16 in several States and Union territories. They will list all structures, houses, and households nationwide to provide a solid foundation for the population enumeration.

The month-long exercise will be notified by each State and Union territory between April 1 and September 30. The field visits will be preceded by a 15-day window for self-enumeration, during which citizens can answer HLO phase questions via a portal.

Citizens will generate a special ID after filling in the required details and answering the questions, which they will provide to enumerators who visit their homes during the HLO process for verification.

India International Water Week to be held in September

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Jal Shakti on Wednesday said the 9th India International Water Week (IIWW) will be held in New Delhi from September 22 to 26, with a focus on climate-resilient water management amid rising concerns over floods, erratic rainfall and water stress.

The event will feature thematic engagements across the water sector, including discussions on conservation, efficient use and sustainable management prac-



tices, Union Jal Shakti Minister CR Patil said at a press conference. A field visit is also planned on the concluding day.

Patil said the second International WASH (water, sanitation and hygiene) conference will be held in parallel at the same venue from

Congress women's wing launches postcard drive for women's quota

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress's women's wing on Wednesday launched a 'postcard campaign', demanding the immediate implementation of 33 per cent reservation for women based on the current Lok Sabha strength of 543 seats.

Under the initiative, the party said the goal is to have 10 lakh women send postcards addressed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, making their



demands. All India Mahila Congress president Aika Lamba, along with Congress SC Department

chairman Rajendra Pal Gautam and the party's OBC Department head Anil 'JaiHind' Yadav, inaugurated the campaign here.

Lamba stated that women would send these postcards to the prime minister's official residence at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg, demanding the immediate implementation of the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 and calling for a separate reservation provision within the Act specifically for OBC women, alongside those for SC and ST women.

NCW proposes survivor-centric policy for acid attack victims

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Commission for Women (NCW) on Wednesday said it has submitted a detailed set of recommendations to multiple central ministries, outlining a survivor-centric framework to strengthen care, justice and rehabilitation for acid-attack victims.

The recommendations, based on a roundtable consultation titled "Navjeevan:



A Consultation on Care, Justice and Dignity for Acid Attack Survivors" held on

January 16, have been sent to the ministries of home affairs, health and family welfare, women and child development and social justice and empowerment.

According to the commission, the recommendations present a holistic, survivor-centric framework addressing medical care, legal justice, rehabilitation, financial security and long-term socio-economic inclusion for acid-attack victims across the country.

46 new assistant commandants join CRPF after passing out parade

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Gurugram

Forty-six trainee officers, including two women, were appointed as assistant commandants to the country's largest paramilitary, the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF), on Wednesday, following a passing out parade at their academy in Gurugram. Union Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar took the salute of the parade.

Addressing the young officers at the CRPF Officers' Training Academy in Kadarpur village (Gurugram) of Haryana, the minister asked them to provide a "strong leadership" to the troops who work in some of the most



"challenging" internal security theatres of the country.

A senior officer said the new officers will soon join various operational units of the CRPF deployed in three main combat theatres of counter-ter-

rorism - in Jammu and Kashmir, in the northeast for anti-insurgency tasks, and across states to tackle anti-Naxal operations.

The recruits joined the CRPF as trainees in March 2025 after clearing an all-India exam conducted by the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC).

The CRPF is among the five Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) under the command of the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).

"The 46 trainees from the 56th Directly Appointed Gazetted Officers (DAGOs) batch include two women. They underwent a 52-week training in combat, administration and leadership apart from other service domains.

Army reaffirms anti-terror resolve on Pahalgam anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On the first anniversary of the deadly Pahalgam terror attack, the Indian Army on Wednesday reaffirmed its steely resolve to fight against terrorism, and said, for acts against India, "the response is assured".

On April 22 last year, terrorists killed 26 people, mostly tourists, at Pahalgam in south Kashmir. The dastardly act had shaken the nation and drawn condemnation from Governments and leaders across the world.

In retaliation, India launched a military opera-



tion codenamed Operation Sindoor early on May 7 and decimated multiple terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

"For acts against India,

the response is assured. Justice will be served. Always. #SindoorAnniversary #JusticeEndures #NationFirst," the Army posted on X.

The post also carried a

digital poster bearing an image portraying three armed soldiers in uniform standing next to each other against a backdrop that depicted a large red circle, with a caption "OPERATION SINDOOR CONTINUES..."

The poster also carried a reference to Operation Mahadev, which was launched soon after the attack to hunt and neutralise perpetrators.

On the eve of the first anniversary of the Pahalgam attack, the Indian Army on Tuesday had said, "When boundaries of humanity are crossed, the response is decisive".

States Focus



RAHUL'S WEST BENGAL RALLIES RESCHEDULED FOR APRIL 25

A day after cancelling Rahul Gandhi's April 23 rallies in Kolkata and Serampore following denial of police permission, the Congress on Wednesday rescheduled them for April 25 after receiving clearance from police authorities, an official said. "The first rally of Rahul Gandhi will be held at Shahid Minar Maidan in Kolkata around 2.30 pm, and the second one will be held at Serampore in Hooghly district on April 25," he said. Earlier, the Congress had cancelled two rallies of Gandhi at Ramlila Park (Park Circus ground) and Metiabruz in Kolkata, and another at Serampore stadium, slated for April 23, after the authorities did not grant the required clearance, he said.



POLL SEIZURES IN BENGAL, TN CROSS ₹1,000 CRORE MARK: ECI

Poll-related seizures, including cash, drugs and liquor meant to allure voters, have crossed the ₹1000 crore mark in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, the Election Commission of India (ECI) said on Wednesday. It said that since the Election Seizure Management System (ESMS) was activated on February 26, enforcement authorities have recovered freebies and allurements worth ₹1072.13 crore in the two States. Tamil Nadu will go to the polls on Thursday in a single phase, along with phase one in West Bengal, where the second phase of voting is slated for April 29. The seizures include ₹127.67 crore in cash, nearly 41,000 litres of liquor worth ₹106.3 crore, drugs worth nearly ₹184 crore and precious metals such as gold and silver worth ₹215 crore.

BENGAL CEO ORDERS CRACKDOWN ON VOTER INTIMIDATION



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

The West Bengal Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) on Wednesday asked police to take immediate preventive action against persons allegedly involved in voter intimidation and disrupting the electoral process, a senior official said.

In a communication to the DGP, the police observer in the CEO's office shared a list of alleged troublemakers across several Assembly constituencies and police station areas for necessary action.

The letter said these individuals were "actively involved in intimidating voters and creating disturbance in the electoral process" and directed field-level officers to act after due diligence and in accordance with the law.

It suggested steps such as registering FIRs, issuing notices under relevant provisions, initiating preventive detention where necessary, stepping up patrolling in sensitive booths and closely monitoring the movement of those named during the poll period.

The CEO's office also asked that a "clear and urgent message" be sent across the police hierarchy that the listed persons must not be allowed to intimidate voters or interfere in the process.

"Any instance of voter intimidation or disturbance caused by any of these persons will be viewed seriously," it said, warning that accountability would be fixed for lapses.

Mamata slams use of armoured vehicles for polls in West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Amdanga (WB)

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday expressed surprise over the deployment of CRPF armoured vehicles for maintaining law and order during the Assembly polls, alleging that the BJP-led Centre has engaged all wings of the Government to work in its favour.

Addressing a TMC rally in North 24 Parganas district, she claimed that central forces such as the CRPF, ITBP, CISF and BSF, along with other central entities including the railways, have been deployed for the elections.

"Elections are a festival of democracy, not for killing anyone," the TMC chief said, urging supporters to lodge FIRs if they face any atrocities.



"Around two lakh central force personnel have been brought into Bengal for the elections. This is unprecedented. Are they trying to intimidate me by deploying so many forces?" she asked.

Challenging the BJP, Banerjee said, "I want to see who has more power — the armoured vehicles or the people," asserting that she

was not afraid of the party. Addressing another rally at Haripal in Hooghly district, the TMC chief asked the Narendra Modi Government to send the armoured vehicles to Manipur instead of West Bengal.

"There has been unrest in Manipur for the last three years," she said, asking Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah to hold a public meeting

in the northeastern State.

"Go and see the difference, in Bengal people of all faiths live together in peace," she said. Claiming that the BJP has deployed security forces from across the country for the Assembly elections, Banerjee said, "Terrorists come and kill Indians in Pahalgam, but they (the BJP Government) cannot act against Pakistan; however, for the Bengal polls, Modi brings in all forces."

April 22 marked the first anniversary of the dastardly attack by Pakistan-based Laskar-e-Taiba at Pahalgam in Jammu and Kashmir that left 26 people, mostly tourists, dead and triggered a four-day military conflict with Pakistan after Indian armed forces retaliated with Operation Sindoor targeting terror infrastructure in Pakistan-controlled territories.

Congress will fail to win even single seat in West Bengal: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Wednesday mounted a sweeping attack on both the Congress and the ruling TMC, claiming that Rahul Gandhi's party would fail to win even a single seat in West Bengal, and that Mamata Banerjee's proximity to the Congress would hasten her political decline.

Addressing a poll rally at Dum Dum area, Shah sought to stitch together several of the BJP's principal poll planks in Bengal — from infiltration and women's safety to 'syndicate raj', dynastic politics and the Babri Masjid issue — while projecting the contest as a decisive battle to end what he called the TMC's "politics of terror".

"I want to tell Rahul Gandhi that in Tamil Nadu

and Puducherry, you will not even cross double digits. In West Bengal, you may not even be able to open your account, and in Assam, the Congress will face its biggest defeat ever," he said.

In a more expansive attack on the Congress leadership, Shah accused party president Mallikarjun Kharge of lowering the level of political discourse under Rahul Gandhi's influence.

"Narendra Modi ji, who eradicated terrorism, is being called a terrorist by Kharge ji. Staying around Rahul Gandhi has started to corrupt Kharge ji's language, too. Listen up, Rahul Gandhi... the more abuses you hurl at Modi ji, the more mud you sling with your insults, the lotus will bloom with even greater pride," he asserted.

Training his guns at Banerjee, Shah said the chief



Union Home Minister Amit Shah waving to a gathering during an election campaign ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in Kolkata PTI

minister was making a political mistake by aligning herself with the Congress.

"Mamata *didi*, you are sitting with this same Congress. Your situation is also going to worsen," he said. The BJP leader also sought to counter the TMC's charge that the saffron party would impose an "outsider" as CM if voted to power in Bengal.

educated in Bengali medium school and a BJP leader".

The remarks were a clear attempt by the BJP to blunt one of the TMC's most persistent campaign lines in the final phase of the election - that the saffron party is controlled by leaders from Delhi and has no rooted Bengali face.

"It is time to remove Mamata didi, who came to power with the slogan of 'Maa, Maati, Manush' but has left Bengal at the mercy of goons. Her only goal now is to make her nephew the chief minister," Shah alleged.

Seeking to tap into urban anger over extortion and the alleged stranglehold of local strongmen, particularly in and around Kolkata, Shah said the BJP had prepared a roadmap for the development of the metropolis and its adjoining areas.

7,000 industries shut during TMC rule in West Bengal: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Wednesday said over 7,000 large industries were shut during TMC rule in West Bengal and claimed that the State, once a leader in multiple sectors, has slipped to the bottom.

Addressing an election meeting at Burrabazar in Kolkata, the senior BJP leader referred to the ancestral residence of Nobel laureate Rabindranath Tagore in Jorasanko locality in Burrabazar and accused the TMC of failing to accord due importance to its heritage status.

"Bengal, which was once a beacon of knowledge, has now witnessed the closure of 7,000 big industries, thousands of MSME units, and loss of jobs for 30 lakh youths," he said.

Alleging that "TMC goondas" had put up images of Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee at Tagore's ancestral house, where the poet spent much of his life and created numerous literary works, Adityanath said the act amounted to an insult.

"Ideally, apart from Tagore, only the idol of Bharat Mata should have been placed there. But TMC does not give due respect to Bharat Mata as it has no love for Bharatiya 'sanskriti'. It is



UP CM Yogi Adityanath addressing a public meeting in support of BJP candidates ahead of the West Bengal Assembly polls in Kolkata PTI

a shame that TMC has brought Bengal, a forerunner of the Renaissance, to such a pass," he said.

Adityanath said to "restore

the lost glory of West Bengal" on the 150th year of the composition of Vande Mataram, the TMC Government should be dislodged, and the BJP

brought to power.

"What has the TMC done to honour the memory of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay? It became the Azadi mantra," he added.

Alleging decades of mis-governance under the Congress, the CPI(M) and the TMC, Adityanath claimed the State had turned into a "graveyard of industries" and said only a "double-engine Government" could restore its past prominence.

Alleging that a senior TMC minister and Firhad Hakim had spoken in favour of spreading Urdu, he said Bengali identity could not be compromised.

"Bengali will remain the language of Kolkata and

Bengal. Bengali '*ashmita*' cannot be hurt by minority-appeasing TMC leaders," he said. The Uttar Pradesh CM also alleged that the TMC Government was imposing curbs on religious processions.

"Bengal is known for the worship of *Maa Kali*, but TMC is putting curbs on *Kali* and *Durga* processions and imposing prohibitory orders in many areas," he said.

"Mamata didi has an allergy to the name of Lord Ram and opposed the Ram temple in Ayodhya. Do you want a Government that is not in sync with our centuries-old emotional attachment to *Bhagwan Ram*?" he asked.

TMC alleges assault by central forces in Nandigram; ECI denies

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Kolkata

The ruling TMC in West Bengal lodged a complaint with the Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday, alleging that central forces personnel used "disproportionate criminal force" on locals in Nandigram in Purba Medinipur district.

An Election Commission official, however, said the complaint was investigated, but no such incident



can be found.

The TMC alleged that CRPF personnel, deployed to ensure free and fair polling, "grossly abused their posi-

tion" by assaulting locals "without any provocation" on April 21, resulting in injuries that required hospitalisation. The party also submitted purported photographs of the injured persons, along with the complaint. Voting will be held on April 23 in Nandigram, from where Leader of the Opposition Suvendu Adhikari is seeking another term.

The TMC has fielded Adhikari's former aide, Pabitra Kar, in the seat.

ECI lists tribunal-cleared voters for Bengal phase 1 polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

The Election Commission of India (ECI) issued booth-wise lists of voters whose cases were disposed of by tribunals, clearing them to participate in the first phase of the West Bengal elections, a senior official said on Wednesday.

The ECI published two separate lists on its website — one of voters whose names have been included following tribunal orders and another of those who remain excluded.

However, the total number of additions and deletions is yet to be dis-



closed. "A comprehensive figure is expected to be available by evening," the official said.

Voters can access the lists by selecting their Assembly constituency and booth number on the official portal. For booths

where no tribunal decisions were made, no names have been listed.

Individuals who approached the tribunal after their names were left out of the rolls can also check their status online using their EPIC numbers.

AIADMK protests against alleged cash distribution in Coimbatore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Coimbatore (Tamil Nadu)

AIADMK candidate for Coimbatore South Assembly constituency Amman K Arjunan staged a protest on Wednesday against the alleged distribution of cash for votes by his rival and former State minister V Senthil Balaji in the constituency.

Arjunan claimed that the "men from Karur" were caught distributing money



to the voters in Coimbatore and expressed concern over the rampant distribution of cash for votes in several parts of the constituency.

Senthil Balaji, however, denied saying that if the Opposition party had evidence, then it should submit it to the Election Commission of India.

Arjunan staged a dharna in front of the Coimbatore district collectorate, alleging widespread distribution of money, and demanded appropriate action against those responsible for the violation of the model code of conduct.

ABHISHEK SLAMS AMIT SHAH FOR DISMISSIVE TONE TOWARD MAMATA

Kolkata: Senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee on Wednesday accused Union Home Minister Amit Shah of showing disrespect to West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee during election campaigns and said it reflected the BJP's attitude towards women. Addressing an election meeting at Joynagar in South 24 Parganas district, Banerjee said Shah's alleged remarks targeting TMC workers would be answered after the poll results on May 4.



"BJP talks about 'Naari Shakti', but we all saw how Amit Shah addressed Mamata Banerjee at a meeting on Tuesday. He was calling her 'Ayeeee Didi', just like Modi did in 2021 'Didi O Didi', both in a dismissive, disrespectful manner," he said. "And remember, he is addressing someone who is 10 years older than him. This is the respect they have for women, for a woman chief minister and for a senior politician," Banerjee added.

He said just as the BJP was restricted to 77 seats after the 2021 elections, "this time they won't be able to cross even 50 seats". Urging Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Shah and other BJP leaders such as Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath to "keep their cool" while campaigning in the State, he alleged that the BJP was targeting the only woman Opposition chief minister who stood against its "dictatorial attitude".

ECI seizes cash from DMK candidate's aide in Chennai



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Chennai

Several cash bundles of ₹500 denomination were confiscated from the residence of an aide of the DMK candidate for Mylapore Assembly constituency by the Election Commission of India's (ECI) flying squad in Chennai on Wednesday, police said.

Confirming the incident, Chennai District Election Officer J Kumaragurubaran said the matter has been forwarded to the officials concerned.

"With the assistance of the flying squad, an inspection was conducted, and necessary action has been taken," the DEO said in a post on the social media platform 'X'. A police official said that, along with the money seized from the Mandavelipakkam residence of Sathyamurthy, an aide of the DMK candidate Dha Velu, by the flying squad, evidence that the money was stashed to be distributed to entice the voters was also obtained.

The cash has been handed over to the Income Tax department for a detailed investigation, the police official said.

Velu is pitted against BJP candidate and former Governor Tamilisai Soundararajan and TVK candidate P Venkataramanan, though there are a total of 19 candidates in the fray from this seat for the April 23 Assembly election.

BJP chief spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathy demanded that Velu be "disqualified" from contesting the election as several crores of rupees meant for distribution have been found in one of his aide's houses by the ECI.

Foreign delegation observes poll preparedness in Siliguri

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata

A 13-member delegation from seven countries visited Siliguri in the northern part of West Bengal on Wednesday to observe the poll preparedness on the eve of the first phase of the assembly elections on April 23, a senior EC official said.

The delegation, comprising representatives from Namibia, Georgia, Nepal, the Philippines, Gambia, Switzerland and Kenya, accompanied officials of the Election Commission to the



Distribution-cum-Reception Centre (DCRC) at Siliguri College ground, he said.

The team reviewed various aspects of India's electoral process, including preparations and on-ground management. Representatives from the International Institute for

Democracy and Electoral Assistance (International IDEA) were also part of the visit, the official added.

Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) and Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) units were distributed from the DCRC during the day, he said, adding that the delegation observed the dispatch of polling personnel to different booths and the distribution of election materials.

"The visit is significant in showcasing the transparency of India's electoral system on the global stage," he said.

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Order Order

UP court reserves order on defamation case



Arguments were heard on Wednesday in a defamation case involving Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, with a local MP-MLA court reserving its order for May 2, officials said.

The hearing before the MP-MLA court focused on an application filed under Section 311 (which empowers a court to call or recall any witness at any stage of a trial if it feels their testimony is necessary for a fair decision) of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), with counsels for both sides presenting their arguments.

Gandhi's counsel Kashi Prasad Shukla said the court heard submissions on the plea moved by complainant's lawyer Santosh Kumar Pandey and fixed May 2 for pronouncement of its order.

The previous hearing in the matter was held on April 17. Earlier, during the March 28 hearing, the complainant had sought examination of Gandhi's voice sample under Section 311 read with Section 91 of the CrPC.

The application requested that Gandhi's voice sample be matched with an already submitted CD at a forensic laboratory. Gandhi's lawyers had opposed the demand.

The defamation case was filed in October 2018 by local BJP politician Vijay Mishra. Gandhi had surrendered before the court on February 20, 2024, following which he was granted bail on two sureties of ₹25,000 each.

Allahabad HC dismisses habeas corpus plea of cow slaughter accused



The Allahabad High Court has dismissed a habeas corpus petition filed by an accused in a cow slaughter case, upholding his detention under the National Security Act (NSA). A bench of Justices JJ Munir and Sanjiv Kumar observed that the matter pertained to "public order" and not merely "law and order".

"We have carefully perused the detention order and find that the matter certainly pertains to public order and not to law and order," the court said. The bench further observed that no one has the right to violate the provisions of the Uttar Pradesh Prevention of Cow Slaughter Act, 1955 and emphasised the need to maintain communal harmony.

The petition was filed by one Sameer through his father Shamshad, challenging his detention ordered by the District Magistrate of Shamli on May 15, 2025 under the NSA. According to the case details, a police team on March 15, 2025 recovered remains of a cow from a field in Lavdaudpur village in Shamli district. An FIR was subsequently registered under relevant sections of the cow slaughter law.

TCS case: Court denies relief to arrested software professional



A court in Maharashtra's Nashik has denied interim protection from arrest to Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) employee Danish Shaikh in another case related to alleged sexual harassment and forcible conversion at the local unit of the leading IT firm.

The 31-year-old software professional is already arrested in one of the nine FIRs registered in connection with the case. He is currently in judicial custody.

He has sought interim bail in the case registered at the Mumbai Naka police station here.

The defence had sought interim protection from arrest until the main plea was decided.

However, the prosecution contended that they needed time to file their response.

After hearing both sides, the court on Tuesday refused interim relief to Shaikh and directed prosecution to file its response by April 27.

In this specific case, Shaikh has been booked under Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) sections 75 (sexual harassment), 299 (deliberate acts to outrage religious feelings) and others.



Naming politicians won't clear Yasin: NIA to Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Wednesday told the Delhi High Court that taking names of senior politicians and bureaucrats does not absolve separatist leader Yasin Malik or negate his links with militants like Hafiz Saeed.

The NIA filed a rejoinder to Malik's reply to its plea for enhancing his life sentence in a terror-funding case to death penalty and asserted that the Jammu and Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) chief was "well connected with multiple terrorist organisations and with supporters of the terrorist organisation LeT" and that he dropped names of senior politicians, media personnel, foreign delegates and bureaucrats to gain popularity and draw public sympathy.

The NIA stated that Malik cannot be permitted to "revisit" the matter when the charges against him have already culminated into his conviction and ample opportunity was



given to him to raise objections. A bench of justices Navin Chawla and Ravidner Dudgea took the NIA's rejoinder on record and listed the agency's appeal for hearing on July 21. The bench also told Malik, who was virtually appearing from Tihar jail, that a copy of the rejoinder would be supplied to him through the jail authorities.

In his reply filed to the NIA's

appeal, Malik had earlier said that he spent nearly three decades as a key figure in a state-sanctioned "backchannel" mechanism, working with a succession of prime ministers, intelligence chiefs, and even business tycoons to foster peace in Jammu and Kashmir.

In an 85-page affidavit, Malik shared details about his journey — from his school days to links with

terrorists and meetings with political leaders. "The convict himself has admitted that he was the commander-in-chief of JKLF. Rest of the matters (in the reply) related to taking names of senior politicians, media personnel, foreign delegates and bureaucrats is only for the sake of gaining popularity and to draw sympathy of the public and has no bearing with the merit of the instant case. It is most respectfully submitted that the mere mention of names of senior politicians and senior bureaucrats does not negate the fact that the convicted accused had linkages with militant Hafiz Saeed and other militants," the NIA said in its rejoinder.

"Yasin Malik has admitted that he was the commander-in-chief of JKLF and he has himself admitted the fact that he was having connection with Sayeed Salauddin, chief of Hizb-ul-Mujahideen," it added.

The NIA, in the rejoinder, also took exception to Malik calling himself a "good sacrificial goat", stating that

such statements were unfair to the judicial process.

Asserting that the case against Malik was based on evidence and not hearsay or "emotional narrations", the NIA said there was material demonstrating that he was in "contact with the top leadership of Pakistan, including the Prime Minister, the President, senators of the Pakistani Senate, and the chief ministers of all provinces, and was using such contacts to propagate narratives against India and to further the secessionist agenda in Jammu & Kashmir".

The agency further said Malik's averments on the plight of Kashmiri Pandits during the 1990s and his sympathy towards them was entirely irrelevant to the instant case.

Similarly, his narratives concerning deceased militant Burhan Wani, his encounter by law enforcement agencies and the subsequent disturbances in law and order was also entirely immaterial, the agency added.

MSCB scam: Court discharges NCP (SP) leader Rohit Pawar, others in ED case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

A special court here on Wednesday discharged NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar and others in a case registered by the Enforcement Directorate in connection with an alleged ₹25,000 crore scam at the Maharashtra State Co-operative Bank (MSCB).

Special judge for MPs/MLAs cases Mahesh Jadhav accepted the discharge applications of all 17 accused and ruled that the case stood closed.

The ED's money laundering case stemmed from an



Rohit Pawar

August 2019 FIR registered by the Mumbai Police's Economic Offences Wing (EOW) that alleged fraudulent sale of 'Sahakari Sakhar Karkhanas' (cooperative sugar mills) by then officers and directors of MSCB at throw-away prices to their relatives

or other private persons without following due procedure. However, a special court for MPs/MLAs cases recently accepted the EOW's closure report in the case.

Rohit Pawar and others named as accused in the ED's case then sought discharge from the money laundering case.

The Central probe agency opposed their pleas, stating that while the closure report was accepted by the lower court, a 2021 writ petition challenging earlier rejection of its intervention application was still pending before the Bombay High Court.

No action against KCR, others based on panel report on Kaleshwaram project: Telangana HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

In a major relief to BRS chief K Chandrasekhar Rao and three others, the Telangana High Court on Wednesday directed that no action be taken against them on the basis of findings of the PC Ghose Commission, which probed the alleged irregularities in the execution of Kaleshwaram irrigation project.

Delivering its orders on a batch of petitions filed by KCR, former minister T Harish Rao and others, a division bench of Chief Justice Aparesh Kumar Singh and Justice GM



Mohiuddin, however, said the constitution of the Commission is neither arbitrary, illegal nor ultra vires of the Constitution.

"...The findings rendered by the Commission as are prejudicial to the conduct

and reputation of the petitioners and have been rendered in violation of principles of natural justice and the statutory safeguard provided under section 8B of the Commissions of Inquiry Act, 1952 shall be inoperative and no action can

be taken on the basis there," the court said. The court had last month adjourned to April 22 its verdict on the petitions.

The commission, headed by retired Supreme Court judge Justice P C Ghose, which had probed the alleged irregularities in the construction of Kaleshwaram Lift Irrigation Project during the BRS rule, had earlier submitted its report to the government.

The report was tabled in the state assembly in August last year and after a discussion, Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy had announced the government's decision to hand over the investigation to CBI.

SC asks Centre to file affidavit on Rajoana's plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Wednesday asked the Centre to file within two weeks its affidavit on a plea by Balwant Singh Rajoana, convicted in the 1995 assassination case of the then Punjab chief minister Beant Singh, seeking commutation of his death sentence to life term due to the delay in deciding his mercy petition.

Rajoana has been incarcerated for more than 29 years, of which he has been on death row for over 15 years.

"Why have you not filed your counter affidavit so far?" a bench of Justices Vikram Nath, Sandeep Mehta and Vijay Bishnoi asked the counsel appearing for the Centre. The counsel said they want to place some documents before the court in a sealed cover.

"You file your counter affidavit otherwise his (Rajoana's) allegations are uncontroverted," the bench said, adding,



Balwant Singh Rajoana

"You place your affidavit whatever you want to say".

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Rajoana, said the mercy plea filed by the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) on behalf of the petitioner in March 2012, is still pending. He said the apex court had in 2023 said the authorities should take a

call on the mercy plea. Rohatgi referred to the top court's September 24 last year order which said that any further request for adjournment in the matter at the instance of the respondents would not be entertained.

The bench granted two weeks to the Centre's counsel to file the affidavit and made clear that no more time would be granted.

The apex court had earlier asked the Centre to take a decision on Rajoana's mercy petition. The Centre had then referred to the sensitivity of the matter and said the mercy petition was under consideration. In September 2024, the top court sought responses from the Centre, the Punjab government and the administration of the Union Territory of Chandigarh on Rajoana's plea.

Former Punjab Chief Minister Singh and 16 others were killed in a blast at the entrance of the civil secretariat in Chandigarh on August 31, 1995.

NCLAT reserves order on Vedanta's pleas against selection of Adani's bid for JAL

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) on Wednesday reserved its order on Vedanta's two petitions against the selection of Adani Enterprises' bid to acquire debt-ridden Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL) through an insolvency process.

A two-member NCLAT bench comprising Chairperson Ashok Bhushan and Member Technical Barun Mitra concluded its hearing following arguments from Vedanta and respondents, including the Resolution Professional, Committee of Creditors (CoC) and Adani

Enterprises. It asked both parties to submit written submissions within the next two days.

Vedanta's counsel questioned the evaluation metrics adopted by JAL lenders, who selected the bid from Adani Enterprises offering ₹14,535 crore and rejected Vedanta's higher bid of ₹17,926 crore.

On March 24, NCLAT declined any interim stay over the Vedanta Group's plea against the order passed by the NCLT on March 17, approving Adani Group's bid.

However, it had said that the plan would be subject to the outcome of the appeals filed by the Anil Agarwal-led Vedanta Group.

This order by NCLAT was



challenged before the Supreme Court, which declined to grant a stay. However, the apex court directed that if the monitoring committee planned to take any major policy

decision, it should first obtain the Tribunal's sanction.

Adani Enterprises had outbid Vedanta and Dalmia Bharat to win the bid for JAL. Adani got the maximum 89 per cent votes from creditors,

followed by Dalmia Cement (Bharat), and Vedanta Group.

The CoC defended its decision, saying the process complied with all Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) rules. They maintained that no bidder has a guaranteed right to win, even if it offers the highest value.

They said plans were evaluated on multiple factors, including upfront cash, feasibility, and execution, not just headline value.

JAL, which has high-quality assets and business interests spanning real estate, cement manufacturing, hospitality, power and engineering & construction, was admitted to the corporate insolvency resolution process (CIRP) in

June 2024, after it defaulted on payments of loans aggregating ₹57,185 crore. JAL has major real estate projects like Jaypee Greens in Greater Noida, a part of Jaypee Greens Wishtown in Noida (both on the outskirts of the national capital), and the Jaypee International Sports City, located near the upcoming Jewar International Airport.

Besides, it has three commercial/industrial office spaces in Delhi-NCR, while its hotel division has five properties in Delhi-NCR, Mussoorie, and Agra.

Also, JAL has four cement plants in Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, and a few leased limestone mines in Madhya Pradesh.



recusal of Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma in the liquor policy case.

The PIL by advocate Vaibhav Singh was listed for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice DK Upadhyaya and Justice Karia, which directed that it be listed before another bench on Thursday.

"This matter will not be heard by this bench. List tomorrow before a bench of which one of us, Justice Tejas Karia, is not a member," the court said.

The counsel for the petitioner requested that the matter be sent to another



that unauthorised sharing of court recordings on social media can undermine the independence of the judiciary and is also prohibited under high court rules.

Several AAP leaders and members of various other opposition parties, including Congress leader Digvijay Singh, however, "intentionally and deliberately recorded and circulated" videos of Kejriwal's appearance before Justice Sharma on April 13 on social media with the intention to malign the image of the court in the eyes of the public, the plea claimed.

Delhi High Court judge recuses himself from hearing contempt PIL against Kejriwal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi High Court judge Justice Tejas Karia on Wednesday recused himself from hearing a PIL seeking contempt action against AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and others for allegedly uploading and sharing clips of the court hearing on the former chief minister's plea seeking

bench dealing with a similar issue.

Besides the AAP leaders, the other parties in the PIL include the high court administration and social media giants Meta Platforms, X and Google.

Justice Karia, a former partner at a leading law firm, represented Meta in several cases before his elevation as a judge.

Singh, in his PIL, submitted



Editor's
TAKE

Pahalgam: If we forget, we fail them

The anniversary is more than remembrance — it tests whether a nation can hold on to memory long enough to find meaning in it, and the resolve to act on it

It is a year since Pahalgam happened. The incident, where 22 innocents were massacred, shocked the nation and shamed humanity. On April 22, 2025, the illusion of peace in Kashmir's Baisaran Valley was shattered as terrorists opened fire on tourists, killing 26 hapless civilians in one of the deadliest attacks in recent years. It was a brazen act, and the manner in which it was carried out was even more horrifying: victims were singled out, questioned, and executed at close range for their religion. They were not only out to terrorise people but to deliver a message to the Indian State — we are unstoppable and will have the last say, a challenge written in blood.

Now, one year on, that challenge still lingers. Have we moved on, normalised the incident, or has it shaped our resolve to eliminate such ruthless terrorists, each one of them? The answer is uncertain. The government and the Army have spoken unequivocally about eliminating it and taking concrete steps to prevent the recurrence of such horrific incidents. "They will never be forgotten," the Prime Minister assured the nation, reaffirming a zero-tolerance approach to terrorism. The Army, too, has invoked resolve, pointing to retaliatory operations like Operation Sindoor as proof that the State remembers and responds. Operation Sindoor was swift and hard-hitting. Yet the scars it left are still bleeding in the memories of people who endured it.

Remembrance is not restricted to the state; it is all-pervasive, every Indian feels the pain. It lives in public consciousness, policy introspection, and honest accounting of what went wrong. If memory is reduced to ritual, it loses its purpose. It is not just about action in the aftermath but about preparedness — a preventive approach that deters perpetrators. The first lesson of Pahalgam is stark: complacency is costly. The attack exposed gaps in intelligence, surveillance, and threat anticipation, allowing militants to strike a crowded tourist zone. Even a year later these lapses need to be plugged. If accountability is blurred, the cost is enormous.

The second lesson is more complex: terrorism in Kashmir is no longer just about terrorising people or claiming territory; it is about shaping a narrative of power. The attackers aimed to divide the society and instill a sense of fear so no one dared to defy them. The response, therefore, must go beyond the military to include political, social, and psychological measures, ensuring such acts do not tear the social fabric.

And what of Pahalgam today? On the surface, there is a return to normalcy. Tourists have begun to trickle back, and systems like QR-based identification for workers have been introduced to tighten security. Yet beneath this recovery lies an uneasy truth: infrastructure remains strained, as seen in the under-resourced local hospital that still struggles a year after bearing the brunt of the tragedy. And for survivors trauma lingers endlessly. India must invest in local infrastructure, and ensure that security measures do not alienate the very communities they aim to protect. Pahalgam must not become just another day of remembrance. Such incidents stop bothering us after a while and that is the real danger!

The cost of stalling women's reservation

The latest impasse over women's reservation in Parliament lays bare a deep contradiction: even as empowerment is loudly championed in public, procedural hurdles and tactical objections continue to stall a transformative reform



GOURAV VALLABH

India stands at a pivotal moment in its democratic evolution, one where the question is no longer whether women deserve one-third political representation, but whether a few family-owned political parties are willing to enable it. The recent inability to advance the operationalisation of women's reservation in Parliament has exposed a troubling contradiction. While the principle of empowering women in governance enjoys broad rhetorical support, sections of the opposition, particularly parties aligned with the INDI bloc, have continued to create hurdles at critical moments. By invoking technical objections around sequencing, delimitation clarity, and procedural conditions, they have effectively stalled progress. The optics were even more striking when, to the surprise of many, some opposition leaders appeared to celebrate the outcome—an outcome that delayed the transfer of political power to women across the country.

In contrast, the government has maintained a clear and consistent position. As Prime Minister Narendra Modi stated in his address to the nation, empowering women through political representation is not a matter of political convenience but a national priority. He emphasised that the government remains committed to delivering this right to the women of India "at any cost," and that while current parliamentary arithmetic may pose constraints, the resolve to implement women's reservation is firm.

The larger issue, however, is not merely political. It is about what India stands to gain or lose from this reform. The case for women's reservation is often framed in terms of fairness, but the more compelling argument is about governance.

India is one of the few countries with strong, large-scale empirical evidence on how women's political participation affects governance outcomes. The landmark research by Raghavendra Chattopadhyay and Esther Duflo provides a clear answer. Studying reserved panchayats in West Bengal and Rajasthan, they found that women-led local governments invested 62 per cent more in drinking water infrastructure in West Bengal and 56 per cent more in Rajasthan compared to their male-led counterparts. These were not symbolic differences; they reflected a systematic reorientation of public spending towards essential services that directly improve quality of life, health outcomes, and productivity. The reason is straightforward. Women leaders bring different lived experiences into decision-making. In the same study, 31 per cent of women identified drinking



INDIA HAS DEBATED WOMEN'S RESERVATION FOR DECADES. THE EVIDENCE IS CLEAR, AND THE BENEFITS ARE UNDENIABLE. WHAT REMAINS IS THE POLITICAL WILL OF A FEW PARTIES. WHEN IMPLEMENTED, THIS REFORM WILL NOT JUST CHANGE WHO SITS IN PARLIAMENT; IT WILL CHANGE HOW INDIA IS GOVERNED

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water as a key public concern, compared to just 17 per cent of men, making women 82 per cent more likely to prioritise it. Representation, therefore, is not just about presence; it is about perspective, and perspective shapes policy.

When such representation scales up to Parliament, the implications are profound. A more gender-balanced legislature is more likely to prioritise issues such as maternal health, nutrition, sanitation, childcare, and safety—areas which have long been under-emphasised but have direct economic consequences. Poor childcare limits workforce participation, unsafe public spaces restrict mobility, and weak health infrastructure increases long-term fiscal burdens. These are not merely "social issues"; they are core economic concerns. Beyond policy priorities, women's participation improves the quality of governance itself. Diverse decision-making bodies are less prone to narrow thinking and more likely to evaluate policies through multiple lenses. This leads to more balanced, inclusive, and effective policymaking. In a country as complex as India, such diversity is not optional; it is essential for responsive governance.

The impact also extends to justice and institutional accountability. Issues such as gender-based violence, workplace harassment, and unequal access to economic opportunities often suffer from inconsistent political attention. A stronger presence of women in legislatures increases the likelihood that these concerns receive sustained focus, better legal frameworks, and more effective enforcement. Governance thus becomes not only more inclusive but also more just. Perhaps the most significant impact is economic. India's female labour force participation remains

below its potential. Structural barriers, ranging from safety concerns to lack of childcare, continue to limit women's full participation in the economy. When policy addresses these constraints, the gains are substantial. Higher female participation expands the labour force, increases household incomes, and strengthens overall economic growth. No country aspiring to become a global economic powerhouse can afford to underutilise half its talent base.

There is also a powerful inter-generational effect. Research by Lori Beaman and her co-authors shows that sustained exposure to women leaders reduces the gender gap in aspirations by 32 per cent among adolescents and by 25 per cent among parents. In simple terms, when young girls see women in positions of authority, they begin to imagine themselves there. Over time, this reshapes education choices, career trajectories, and the very structure of opportunity.

The Modi government's broader policy framework has laid the foundation for this shift. Initiatives such as Beti Bachao Beti Padhao, Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana, Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana, and Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana have expanded women's access to education, health, finance, and entrepreneurship, with Mission Shakti integrating these efforts.

India has debated women's reservation for decades. The evidence is clear, and the benefits are undeniable. What remains is the political will of a few parties. When implemented, this reform will not just change who sits in Parliament; it will change how India is governed. And every delay is not just a procedural pause; it is a missed opportunity to improve governance and accelerate India's progress.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The quiet practice of sustaining yourself daily



SHARMILA DAS

2ND OPINION

There are days when the world seems to have misplaced its instruction manual. Nothing is dramatically broken, yet nothing feels entirely in place. Emails multiply with suspicious enthusiasm, conversations trail off unfinished, and beneath it all lingers a quiet, persistent question: what is the point of all this? On such days, sustainability appears as an abstract ideal—something debated in policy rooms and global summits, distant from the lived reality of a restless mind and an overworked body.

But what if sustainability begins much closer to home? Closer than policies or pledges. Closer than climate targets and conscious consumption. What if it begins with the simple act of sustaining oneself? At first glance, that sounds almost too easy. After all, we are functioning—moving through our routines with reasonable efficiency. Yet a more

honest look reveals something else: we are often running on fragments of attention, borrowed energy, and a body that has quietly learned not to interrupt. This is where yoga enters the frame—not as a performance of perfect postures, but as a gentle interruption to this slow depletion.

It begins with something disarmingly simple: the breath. A slow inhale, followed by a slightly longer exhale. It can feel underwhelming, even inadequate, as if something so basic cannot possibly address the complexity of modern life. But the breath, in yogic practice, is not merely physiological—it is connective. It bridges the gap between a mind that races ahead and a body that struggles to keep pace. In its steady rhythm, attention begins to return.

We rarely lose attention all at once. It slips away in fragments—through notifications, distractions, and thoughts that lead nowhere useful. By day's end, exhaustion often comes not from effort, but from dispersion. The breath gathers this scattered energy, gently but persistently, calling the mind back.

Soon, the body joins this quiet process. For too long, it has been relegated to the background, consulted only when it protests. Yoga shifts that relationship, inviting the body into awareness. A stretch reveals tension long held. A bend uncovers forgotten spaces. A moment of imbalance reminds us that stability is not fixed, but practised. In this rediscovery, there is even a touch of humour—the realisation that your shoulders have been

holding on to conversations long finished, or that your spine, given attention, can move with ease. Movement, then, becomes more than exercise; it becomes restoration.

Between breath and movement, the mind, too, begins to soften. Thoughts gather, emotions shift, and clarity feels distant. The instinct is often to suppress or spiral. Yoga proposes something quieter: observation. To sit, to breathe, and to notice—without reacting. A thought arises; you acknowledge it and return to the breath. A memory surfaces; you let it pass. In that space, a more sustainable way of being begins to emerge. This is not dramatic transformation. It builds in small increments: a few minutes of stretching, a conscious breath before a difficult moment, a pause where there might once have been reaction. Individually small, together they form a rhythm that does not deplete. The meaning of sustainability then shifts. Before

we can sustain the world, we must learn to sustain ourselves. A restless mind cannot hold clarity. An ignored body cannot sustain energy. A driven spirit cannot sustain joy. Yet we expect all three to function seamlessly. Yoga does not resolve life's uncertainties. It

offers a way to remain steady within them—to breathe when things feel constricted, to move when stuck, and to pause when everything insists on urgency.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is a trained Sivananda Yoga teacher

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Iran's strait strategy unclear

Donald Trump stated that a ceasefire ahead of the first round of US-Iran talks would depend on Iran ensuring the full and immediate reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. In practice, however, developments diverged from this position. During the initial round of negotiations, Iran continued restricting shipping routes, and no ceasefire was announced in Lebanon, a key Iranian demand. Despite this, gradual signals of de-escalation emerged. The United States first indicated the possibility of a ceasefire in Lebanon, followed by Iran's foreign minister linking the full reopening of commercial shipping lanes to such a ceasefire. However, Iran's references to a "remaining period of ceasefire", "coordinated routes", and "commercial shipping" suggest that it continues to retain strategic control over the Strait. It remains unclear whether Iran will persist in using control over the Strait as a bargaining tool until its demands are met by the United States, or whether it is willing to de-escalate independently, provided there are reciprocal US military concessions. It is equally uncertain whether this leverage is intended to dilute US pressure on its nuclear programme, or whether nuclear negotiations are proceeding independently.

RITI DWIVEDI | INDORE

Words that damage credibility

Apropos "Kharge's PM jibe triggers BJP's backlash" (Apr 22), Mallikarjun Kharge's description of Prime Minister Narendra Modi as a "terrorist" is not merely offensive—it reflects political self-sabotage. As AICC President of a 140-year-old party and a leader with over five decades in public life, Kharge carries significant responsibility. Yet such a remark reveals a concerning lack of political restraint. Narendra Modi governed Gujarat for over 12 years and has served nearly 12 years as Prime Minister—24 consecutive years in high executive office, each secured through public mandate. His tenure is defined by continuity in governance and policy-driven transformation. No proven personal corruption allegation has marked his career.

To equate a democratically elected leader with a terrorist blurs the distinction between governance and violence. Kharge's subsequent clarification that he "did not intend" such a label—rings unconvincing. Intent is reflected in words spoken, not withdrawn.

The Congress party's electoral decline stems from erosion of public trust, not the existence of political opponents. Resorting to such rhetoric risks further damage to its credibility and weakens the standards of democratic discourse.

N SADHASIVA REDDY | BENGALURU

Protect Assam's cultural traditions

The traditional buffalo fights of Assam, historically associated with rural festivals such as Magh Bihu, merit protection within the constitutional framework of cultural rights, subject to reasonable regulation ensuring animal welfare. As a long-standing rural practice linked to agrarian cycles, these events form an integral part of Assamese intangible cultural heritage. Courts have recognised that traditional practices should not be dismissed solely for differing from modern sensibilities but must be assessed in their socio-cultural context.

Such festivals also generate local economic activity, supporting farmers, breeders, and small vendors. A blanket ban would disproportionately impact rural livelihoods connected to these traditions. A calibrated regulatory approach would better balance economic rights with ethical considerations. While the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, 1960 prohibits unnecessary suffering, it does not mandate an outright ban on all traditional human-animal interactions. Authorities can instead enforce safeguards such as veterinary supervision, restrictions on harmful practices, and penalties for mistreatment. Judicial precedents uphold animal dignity with scope for balance.

NOOPUR BARUAH | TEZPUR

SUPREME COURT FLAGS HIGHWAYS TURNING INTO DEADLY ACCIDENT TRAPS

Recently, the Supreme Court expressed serious concern that national highways in the country are turning into accident traps rather than symbols of progress. A bench comprising Justices JK Maheshwari and Atul Chandurkar directed a nationwide ban on illegal parking on highways. The Court prohibited heavy vehicles from stopping or parking on the main carriageway and shoulders, emphasising that road safety is directly linked to the right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution.

Every year, India loses nearly 3 per cent of its GDP due to road accidents, a deeply worrying statistic for a developing nation. Even more alarming is that most victims fall within the 18-45 age group, the most productive segment of the population. Although national highways

constitute only about 2 per cent of the total road network, they account for nearly 30-36 per cent of road accident deaths. On high-speed highways, suddenly encountering a stationary truck can prove fatal.

Unauthorized roadside dhabas and commercial establishments further worsen the situation by increasing congestion and creating hazards. Statistics underline the severity: in 2024 alone, over 54,000 deaths were reported on national highways—more than 150 lives lost daily.

While highways represent development, ensuring safety is equally crucial. The Supreme Court's intervention is timely and necessary to prevent highways from becoming corridors of death.

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Why nuanced oversight of social media platforms matter

Social media poses significant challenges to ensuring good governance. Platforms, intentionally or otherwise, may enable the rapid dissemination of fake news and propaganda, which can polarise societies and undermine informed decision-making



SANDIP CHATTERJEE

Journalism is considered the “fourth pillar” of democracy, alongside the legislature, executive, and judiciary. It acts as a watchdog, ensuring accountability, transparency, and informed public opinion. A free press guards against the misuse of power and acts as a vital bridge between the government and citizens. Traditional media, such as print and television, have been performing these duties for years, contributing to India as a vibrant and evolving democracy. The content in these media is relatively static, reasonably edited, and validated to ensure factual correctness, with scheduled publication cycles for a limited geography. Journalists shoulder responsibility for such content. Social media, however, thrives on participation, turning passive viewers into creators and amplifiers, unlike print media’s fixed format. This fosters discussion but also risks echo chambers, contrasting with digital media’s controlled navigation. Content evolves in real time via edits or threads on social platforms, while print is immutable once published. Traditional media allows revisions but lacks the crowd-sourced dynamism of social media platforms. In print and digital media, content undergoes mandatory editorial processes, and thus the output is duly validated, whereas social media content becomes challenging when based on falsehood or mala fide intent. Social media poses significant challenges to ensuring good governance. Platforms, intentionally or otherwise, may enable the rapid dissemination of fake news and propaganda, which can polarise societies and undermine informed decision-making. During events such as the 2020 Delhi riots, false narratives exacerbated tensions, complicating government efforts to maintain order. This viral nature often outpaces fact-checking, leading to public outrage or misguided protests. Algorithms create filter bubbles that reinforce biases and limit exposure to diverse views. During the CAA protests, such echo chambers fuelled division rather than dialogue, making effective communication challenging for authorities. Governments also face intense public scrutiny online, where even a single misstep can trigger widespread backlash requiring immediate response. Limited resources for monitoring and moderation further strain capacities, especially during coordinated disinformation campaigns. Efforts to counter such threats are often met with concerns related to surveillance and privacy. Recently, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) has proposed amendments to the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021. These draft amendments seek to revise the framework for regulating online news and current affairs content, as well as to strengthen compliance with advisories and directions issued by the Ministry. While the changes may be clarificatory and procedural in nature, if implemented well, they can help create a safer and more accountable internet, improve legal certainty, and address concerns arising from misinformation and harmful content. An open, safe, trusted, and accountable internet is a citizen’s right. The expanded role of the Inter-Departmental Committee (IDC) allows it to consider a broader range of matters beyond complaints. This could enable better scrutiny of illegal content and a quicker response to rapidly spreading misinformation. The amendments also clarify that data retention obligations under the IT Rules operate “without prejudice” to other laws, potentially supporting investigative and legal processes. Critics argue that the amendments represent an expansion of executive power over online speech. The insertion of Rule 3(4), which mandates intermediary compliance with government directions as a condition for retaining safe harbour under Section 79 of the IT Act, is seen as beyond the rule-making powers of the Act. Faced with the risk of losing safe harbour, intermediaries may over-comply, potentially leading to excessive censorship. Concerns have also been



IN THIS EMERGING SCENARIO, BRINGING SOCIAL MEDIA PLATFORMS AND CONTENT CREATORS UNDER AN APPROPRIATE OVERSIGHT FRAMEWORK BECOMES ESSENTIAL FOR SUSTAINING A VIBRANT DEMOCRACY AND SUPPORTING ECONOMIC GROWTH

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raised about the broad definition of “news and current affairs content”, potentially bringing a wide range of user-generated content, including social media posts and video commentaries, under regulatory purview. Not clearly addressing whether generative AI platforms qualify as intermediaries may lead to enforceability issues. While the government aims to create a more accountable and safer online environment, critics caution that such provisions, if applied broadly, could undermine media independence and create a climate of over-censorship. It is relevant to refer to judicial developments in this context. The Karnataka High Court, in September 2025, dismissed X Corp’s (formerly Twitter) challenge against the Central Government’s “Sahyog” portal, a tool for issuing content takedown notices to social media platforms. This order explicitly validates the government’s regulatory power under the IT Act for public order and security, stating that foreign platforms must comply with Indian laws and cannot claim absolute Article 19 rights. The High Court ruling aligns with Article 19(2) restrictions on free speech for sovereignty and public order. The court described Sahyog as an “instrument of public good”, promoting cooperation between platforms and authorities, and rejected claims of overreach. It did not delve deeply into specific amendment challenges but reinforced that regulation is constitutionally permissible when proportionate. The Karnataka High Court decision provides key precedent affirming government authority despite ongoing debates. The growing scale of information operations adds another dimension. Algorithmic bots and coordinated networks are increasingly shaping online discourse. Advances in artificial intelligence have enabled the creation of deepfake videos, which are difficult to detect and have a stronger impact than text-based misinformation. With enhanced scale and automation, such technologies pose serious challenges to democratic systems and public trust. In this emerging scenario, bringing social media platforms and content creators under an appropriate oversight framework becomes essential for sustaining a vibrant democracy and supporting economic growth. As social media continues to evolve, regulatory frameworks must also adapt. The proposed amendments seek to strengthen accountability within the existing legal framework and do not confer any additional powers on the government. Ensuring that such measures are implemented with transparency, proportionality, and respect for constitutional principles will be key to achieving a balanced and effective digital ecosystem.

India’s EV boom faces recycling test



BISHAL KALITA | MEGHA JAIN

The coming wave

India’s demand for lithium-ion batteries is projected to reach 132 GWh annually by 2030, with cumulative demand nearing 800 GWh. Given that most EV batteries last 8 to 10 years, the first major wave of end-of-life (EoL) batteries from the 2020-2025 adoption cycle will emerge in the early 2030s.

At the same time, battery waste is expected to rise sharply-sixfold by 2030 and fiftyfold by 2035 compared to 2025 levels. EVs alone could account for 45 per cent of battery waste by 2030 and up to 70 per cent by 2035. This creates a dual challenge: managing environmental risks while capturing the economic value embedded in these batteries.

India’s recycling ecosystem, however, is far from ready. Current recycling capacity stands at around 2 GWh, while potential demand could reach 128 GWh by 2030. Bridging this gap would require a nearly 60-fold expansion in capacity within a decade. This mismatch sits at the core of India’s energy security and circular economy ambitions.

Waste or resource?

India is highly dependent on imports for critical minerals such as lithium, cobalt, and nickel, which are key components of lithium-ion batteries. Demand for these materials is expected to surge sharply over the next two decades, while global supply constraints are already emerging. In this context, spent EV batteries represent a domestic source of critical minerals. Recycling can recover significantly more usable material than traditional mining, while also reducing emissions. In effect, discarded batteries are not waste; they are urban mines. The opportunity is clear. The challenge lies in aligning policy, infrastructure, and market incentives to capture this value at scale.



From policy to practice

India has already established a regulatory framework through the Battery Waste Management Rules, 2022, alongside broader initiatives on Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR). However, the gap lies in execution. Bridging this will require targeted interventions across four key areas.

- **First, fixing EPR economics:** The current EPR system suffers from underpriced recycling certificates, often failing to cover the true cost of environmentally sound recycling. This creates a risk of “paper compliance”, where obligations are met on paper without actual material recovery. Revising floor prices, particularly in a chemistry-specific manner, is essential. For instance, lithium iron phosphate (LFP) batteries, widely used in two- and three-wheelers, yield fewer recoverable materials than other chemistries and therefore require stronger financial incentives. Without this correction, recycling may remain economically unattractive.
- **Second, enabling battery traceability:** A robust tracking system is critical to ensure accountability across the battery lifecycle. The proposed “battery passport”—a digital record capturing origin, composition, usage, and end-of-life handling—can play a transformative role. However, moving from concept to implementation will require coordination across regulators, manufacturers, and recyclers. A standardised traceability system would improve compliance, reduce leakages, and support long-term policy enforcement.
- **Third, integrating the informal sector:** India’s informal recycling sector already plays a significant role in waste collection but operates without adequate safety or environmental safeguards. Policy should aim to integrate it into formal systems. Cluster-based common facility centres, supported under existing MSME programmes, can provide shared infrastructure, training, and safer working conditions. Incentivising private players to partner with these networks can further strengthen the ecosystem.
- **Fourth, unlocking second-life applications:** EV batteries typically retain 70-80 per cent of their capacity after retiring from vehicles, making them suitable for secondary uses such as energy storage. Extending battery life through repurposing can significantly improve overall economics. However, this requires clear regulatory standards, particularly around performance testing, liability, and end-use applications. Government procurement policies, especially in sectors such as renewable energy and telecom, can help create early demand for second-life batteries.

A narrow but real opportunity

A well-functioning recycling ecosystem could meet up to 14 per cent of India’s battery material demand by 2030 and unlock a multi-billion-dollar market. More importantly, it could reduce import dependence and strengthen domestic supply chains for critical minerals. The EV transition does not end with adoption. It extends to how efficiently the system recovers, reuses, and reintegrates the materials that power it. If managed well, battery recycling can become a cornerstone of India’s clean energy strategy, turning a looming waste challenge into a source of long-term strategic advantage.

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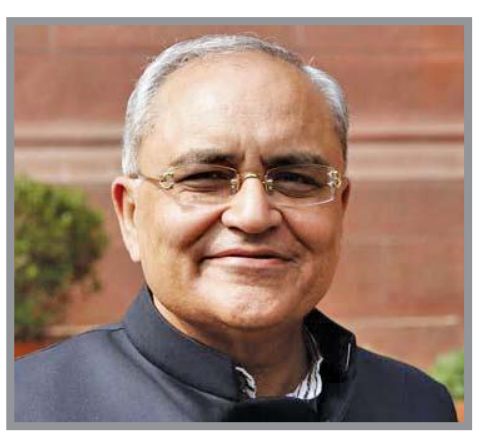
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 The Pioneer

PRANAY KUMAR

The noted thinker, writer, columnist, and former Member of Parliament Balbir Punj is no more. Even if the mind comes to accept this reality, the heart refuses to do so. It is extremely difficult to decide what to write, how to write, where to begin, and where to end. At times, the departure of a towering personality creates such a void that it may perhaps never be filled. The passing of Balbir Punj evokes a similar sense of profound emptiness. He was a personality who constantly inspired and encouraged those engaged in reading and writing. Whenever a writer, columnist, or journalist associated with national discourse produced a noteworthy article, he would offer his comments on it, share it with his acquaintances for wider readership, and often personally call the author to discuss its strengths, areas requiring improvement, and suggest which thinkers should be read to develop a deeper understanding of the subject. This was indeed a rare quality, especially in a person who himself was an established thinker, a two-time Member of Parliament in the Rajya Sabha, a key intellectual strategist of the Bharatiya Janata Party, and someone who had held significant organisational responsibilities. His simplicity, humility, accessibility, and absence of ego not only impressed but at times appeared almost unbelievable. If any writer, journalist, or columnist was going through health-related or other personal difficulties, he never failed to enquire about their well-being. Even when contact details were not readily

available, he would obtain them through acquaintances, reach out, and stand by them in moments of distress. In today’s time, when relationships are increasingly becoming formal and distant, such warmth and personal concern are truly rare. Even in his eighth decade, his level of activity was remarkable. He remained continuously engaged in writing, reflection, and intellectual discourse. Across numerous WhatsApp groups, he not only shared his own articles but also read others’ writings and comments with great attention, offering thoughtful and substantive responses. At times, he would share other important articles and encourage everyone to read them. His writing continued until just three or four days before his passing, which stands as a testament to his discipline and commitment. For him, writing was not merely a medium of expressing ideas but a form of spiritual discipline. He often said that if Ram Ji had bestowed the power of the pen, it must be used for the service of the nation, dharma, and culture. In this, he believed, lay the true fulfilment and purpose of life. He would inspire writers, journalists, and editors to treat writing as their most powerful instrument. Compared to events and gatherings, writing leaves a more enduring impact. A disciplined and refined pen alone can leave an indelible imprint on the tablet of time. In this context, he would often speak of drawing inspiration from Sita Ram Goel, Ram Swarup, and Dharampal, noting that the world came to truly understand the depth and significance of their writings after their time. His understanding of any subject was remark-



ably deep and expansive. He did not remain confined to the surface of events but went to their roots and analysed them in depth. His grasp of Indian discourse and narratives was exceptional. In this context, his book Narratives ka Mayaajaal, published by Prabhat Prakashan, is of great significance. His writings left no room for shallow or sentimental emotionalism. He presented arguments with clarity and facts with authenticity. This is precisely why it was not easy even for his critics to refute his ideas. He had undertaken a deep study of Indian civilisation, Sanatan culture, and its history. At the same time, he had carried out a nuanced analysis of Abrahamic civilisations. As a result, he was able to present a realistic picture of the civilisational conflicts unfolding at the global level. He recognised the liberal, plural, and coexistent

nature of Hindutva, yet remained equally alert to the present and potential challenges confronting it. Through his writings, he repeatedly cautioned society about these challenges and emerging threats. He believed that a fragmented society cannot effectively face any ideological or social challenge. Therefore, throughout his life, he emphasised the importance of an organised society. He was convinced that an unorganised Hindu society cannot withstand the combined pressures of leftist, jihadist, and Eurocentric forces. He dedicated his entire life to making society aware of the need for unity and organisation. In personal conversations, he pointed out areas for organisational improvement, yet in public he upheld discipline and dignity above all. He believed larger goals require commitment, discipline, and sacrifice. Closely aligned with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, he regarded its volunteers as spiritual practitioners and credited them with fostering pride in nation, dharma, and culture. He remained concerned about the persistence of leftist and colonial mindsets in intellectual spaces and stressed that the key battle of the twenty-first century would be over narratives. He consistently encouraged the youth to read and write. He was also deeply concerned about changing demographic patterns and their social implications. He was working on a comprehensive book on this subject and had studied hundreds of texts for it. His thinking was not abstract but grounded in reality and supported by facts. The pain of the Partition of India repeatedly found expression in his writings and reflections. He was

troubled by the fact that society had not drawn the necessary lessons from that historical and tragic experience. He would often say that if a society fails to learn from its past, it is bound to repeat the same mistakes in the future. He regarded changing demographic structures, religious conversions, infiltration, and proportional imbalances in population as serious concerns, and urged society to remain vigilant about them. According to him, self-clampany or a refusal to face reality could prove detrimental to society. Therefore, he wanted Hindu society to overcome distortions arising from misplaced virtues at the earliest. Today, when Balbir Punj Ji is no longer among us, the realisation becomes even more profound that the nation has lost a vigilant, fearless, truth-seeking, and deeply committed ideological sentinel. His life will continue to remind us that unwavering dedication to a higher purpose, along with complete commitment to dharma, culture, and the nation, alone gives true meaning to life. At a time when writing in favour of Hindutva, national thought, and Sanatan culture was not easily accepted, he chose the path of conviction, stood firmly for the nation, and remained steadfast throughout his life. Undoubtedly, his memories and writings will continue to inspire future generations with commitment, courage, and a deeply rooted national consciousness.

The writer is an educationist and senior columnist

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

NoC TO NSE



If things go forward in the same positive vein, the National Stock Exchange (NSE) may get rid of a sharp Damocles’ Sword that has menacingly hung over its head for a decade. According to media reports, the stock market regulator, Sebi, took the first crucial step in the resolution of the cases related to the fraudulent co-location and dark fibre cases. Its high-powered committee recommended a final settlement, which will be considered by a panel of two whole-time members. Last year, NSE offered almost ₹1,400 crore to settle the matter. Sebi’s committee has come up with a higher figure, nearly ₹1,900 crore, which includes ₹1,200 crore “towards disgorgement,” ₹380 crore in interest, and the remaining “under other settlement terms.” Base penalty, severity of the crimes, settlement timing, past violations, and other factors determine the final figure. NSE, which wants a speedy resolution, is likely to agree to the higher figure. The cases were among the major impediments that stalled its proposed IPO (Initial Public Offering) for years. Sebi’s chairman hinted several times in the recent past that the IPO will hit the market this year.

According to a media report, “The NSE faced allegations that some brokers got preferential access through the co-location facility at the stock exchange, early login and dark fibre, which can allow a trader a split-second faster access to data feed of an exchange. Even a split-second faster access is considered to result in huge gains for a trader.” A whistle-blower revealed that a few brokers logged into the NSE systems “with better hardware specifications,” and used algorithmic trading to take advantage of the unfair, faster access. This allowed them to read the market situation faster, figure out buys and sells in queue, for example, and make the trades based on what was about to happen. In the US, traders try to locate closer to the tech headquarters of exchanges, lay down fibres at their own costs to find the shortest route to them, and use the latest equipment to achieve the same results. They get the information a second or maybe less than a second faster, which allows their computers to make faster trades, and even predict what will happen 5-10 seconds later. Many hedge funds were able to beat the big traders for a while till everyone caught on to the ‘trade’ secret.

Obviously, it is not over for the NSE. The so-called settlement figure of the committee will be sent to the two-member panel, which is the final authority on such issues. It has the “final authority to accept or reject the settlement application.” Once the settlement is approved, the two parties will agree to settle out of court, with the NSE neither admitting nor denying its guilt in the cases. The two parties will withdraw the cases from the Supreme Court, and pave the way for the final payment, and a successful settlement and resolution. According to an agency report, SEBI is likely to issue a demand letter to the NSE to deposit the money, before an order to finalise the settlement. Of course, it will open the gateway for the proposed IPO, which is eagerly awaited by a section of investors for years. As of yesterday, the share price of NSE ruled at just below ₹2,000 in the grey market. From May 2021, it moved from below ₹400 to a high of nearly ₹2,400 in May 2025, before it began to slide downwards. In January 2026, it was 2,100, and lost almost five per cent, possibly due to the decline in the broad indices, and other stocks due to several reasons, including the Iran war.

With the Sebi development, a news report stated, “The NSE IPO has been one of India’s most closely-watched yet repeatedly delayed public offerings. Since filing its draft papers in 2016, the exchange has faced multiple roadblocks, including allegations in the co-location case, governance lapses, and concerns around technology infrastructure. These issues led Sebi to withhold approval, keeping the IPO in limbo for years.” Hence, there is excitement that “after nearly a decade, India’s largest stock exchange may finally be inching towards its long-awaited public listing.” The IPO is “back in focus after a key regulatory hurdle appears to have been cleared.” Some media reports indicate that it was due to the efforts of the new Sebi chairman, who set up an internal committee to “revisit the NSE IPO matter.” According to some estimates, the NSE IPO may be among the country’s largest-ever public offerings, “with a projected size of ₹21,000-25,000 crore.” This may value the exchange at ₹5,00,000 crore. “The development (IPO) also holds significant implications for three state-owned general insurance companies. It was earlier reported that National Insurance... Oriental Insurance... and United India Insurance sitting on sizable stakes in NSE could find unexpected relief from the bourse’s long-awaited listing,” states a media report. One needs to wait to know if the NSE IPO will be a purely offer-for-sale to offer exits to the existing investors. It is likely that the exchange will not want the money, unless it decides to invest in tech, and related infrastructure, and expand further.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | THURSDAY | APRIL 23, 2026



BUSINESS10

Follow the storages, not oil wells

The US wants to stop the flow of Iranian oil to stop the war

It is a matter of days, maybe two or three, before Iran’s crude oil storage capacity on Kharg Island, which accounts for 90 per cent of its exports, and is blocked by the US military, is full. This is the new grand strategy that the US president, Donald Trump, has dreamed up to finish the ongoing war. Once there is nowhere to store the oil, Iran will be forced to shut its “fragile... oil wells.” If the island remains blockaded, the stored oil cannot be shipped out. It will be a classic economic squeeze, which will force Iran to come to the peace table.

However, Iran has maintained its own blockade of the Strait of Hormuz, through which 25-30 per cent of the global crude oil passed through each year before the war. In effect, it has imposed huge economic costs on the global suppliers and buyers, and the repercussions are even felt in the retail markets in the US. Since Iran has millions of barrels floating on the open sea, which can easily be sold to earn huge revenues, it has an economic buffer to counter the US blockade. Iran wants Kharg Island to be open before serious peace talks can begin.

Of course, there is a Trump deadline, a temporary two-week ceasefire announced on April 8, which is now extended till Iran’s storage achieves full capacity. There is an Iran counter, which maintains that the Strait will remain choked until Kharg Island is un-choked. Producers have found alternate routes to bypass the Strait, at least temporarily, and in parts. The International Maritime Organisation (IMO) is preparing a massive evacuation plan for the hundreds of vessels that are stranded in the Strait, but it will be activated only when there are “clear

signs of de-escalation in regional tensions” from both the sides.

“Based on the fact that the Government of Iran is seriously fractured, not unexpectedly so and, upon the request of Field Marshal Asim Munir, and Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, of Pakistan, we have been asked to hold our Attack on the Country of Iran until such time as their leaders and representatives can come up with a unified proposal,” Trump announced in a post on Truth Social. He added that the US would continue the blockade, and remain “ready and able.” In effect, he candidly admitted that he had indeed extended the ongoing two-week ceasefire “until such time as their (Iran’s) proposal is submitted, and discussions are concluded, one way or the other.”

Instead of mere economic sanctions, and a freeze on Iran’s global financial and other assets, which are in place, America has gone a few steps further. It aims to squeeze Iran’s economy, which depends on oil exports from the Kharg Island. “The US Treasury will continue to apply maximum pressure through Economic Fury to systematically degrade Teheran’s ability to generate, move, and repatriate funds. Any person or vessel facilitating these flows, through covert trade and finance, risks exposure to US sanctions,” warned Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent. He feels that restraining Iran’s sea trade will target “revenue lifelines.”

Some experts think that the grand plan may not work in a few days. For years, despite the sanctions, Iran was able to both siphon out oil, and funnel in revenues through legal and illegal

channels. These illicit methods are quite robust and stable, and will be used to sell millions of barrels of oil on the high seas, and bring back the dollars, and yuan. China will be an over-eager buyer. In addition, Iran will charge premiums on the sales, which will boost revenues. Everything depends on how porous the US blockade is. It is easier for Iran to control the Strait compared to the US’ ability to choke Kharg Island.

As the world waits for some sort of a peace to emerge, the IMO is holding discussions on operational evacuation details that include the priority of the departure of the vessels in the Strait “based on how long crews have been stranded, along with other logistical and safety considerations.” Of course, the IMO will interact with Iran and Oman, which together proposed the traffic separation scheme to route the vessels in the region, which was adopted in 1968. The complication is that during the war, Iran devised a new routing system, which includes “coastal navigation paths and, in some cases, associated payments.”

As recent experiences indicate, the IMO, apart from the various regional nations, will need to deal with possible irregularities and illegalities. According to reports, there were recent incidents related to security, as shipowners resorted to fraudulent communications, and talked about “fake passage arrangements.” Once the Strait is open, after peace is declared, there will be a hurry among the owners, crews, insurers, and buyers to expedite the process. There will be attempts to surreptitiously enable their ships to leave before the others. This can create confusion, random accidents, and logistics uncertainty.

Most nations want a speedy resolution, a solution that enables both sides to come to the table, and claim victory to their constituents. The easiest way is for both to declare the end of the respective blockades. Iran keeps the Strait free, and the US sails away from Kharg Island. But the world has figured out that while it watched Iran’s nuclear progress, it had a more powerful ticking bomb in its possession. “Iran’s most powerful weapon is not a (nuclear) bomb. It is the geography it controls,” stated a media report, which implied the Strait.

Think about it. A narrow 21-mile choke point in the sea, which allows for a few safe lanes of shipping. One does not need to sink dozens of ships, as a single episode creates a credible and long-sustaining threat. “Military planners call this anti-access/area-denial strategy. The goal is not to defeat the US Navy in open battle. The goal is to create conditions so dangerous that commercial shipping simply refuses to enter,” explains the same report. Now, the US has done the same, fighting military-commerce RDX with a similar dynamite.

It is a matter of who blinks first. The US feels Iran will because it will run out of storage, shut the wells, and be deprived of the revenues. Iran thinks there will be additional pressure on the US, which has built over three weeks, if it can resist for maybe a week or so. Both sides know the implications, and do not wish to be the first one to bat their eyelids.

OUR TAKE

A Contrarian Investor

Daily spends lead to credit boom

Indians borrow more to consume rather than build assets

25 per cent. At the same time, ‘other personal loans,’ which is a category dominated by unsecured lending, expanded from 21.2 per cent to 26.3 per cent, and comprised the second-largest segment after home loans, although the percentage was almost half of the latter. As other surveys indicate, travel loans are on the rise.

What these trends signal is that Indians use unsecured credit to fund entertainment, holidays, and discretionary spending. There is a growing comfort among them to use short-term loans to finance routine purchases. There is a rising demand for quick, flexible, and collateral-free credit. The case of the shift in financing of consumer durables possibly shows that seemingly-small-ticket purchases have shifted to credit cards and personal loans, instead of dedicated financing options. Now, we use credit cards to pay for airline

tickets, hotels, fine dining, movie tickets, and even to purchase monthly groceries.

Lenders too are excited, or at least were until recently. “Since FY-2016, lenders have prioritised retail credit, initially due to weak corporate loan demand, and later due to a change in household credit behaviour. The post-pandemic strengthening of bank balance sheets further supported this trend, as this enabled banks and NBFCs (non-banking firms) to aggressively expand personal loan portfolios, nearly doubling retail credit’s footprint from 10.1 per cent of GDP in FY-2016 to 18.1 per cent in FY-2025,” stated the report. This has created a fear among some experts that Indians are excessively overleveraged in debt.

Other trends amplify these credit trends. For example, fintech-led innovations such as Buy Now, Pay Later (BNPL), and data-driven underwriting made access to unsecured

credit faster, and more widespread. Clearly, India’s retail credit landscape has undergone a structural shift, as consumption drives the incremental growth rather than asset creation. More importantly, the fear that had set in due to personal defaults on credit cards, and unsecured credit in the 2010s, is vanishing, as borrowers become smart and savvy.

But, as many individuals figure out in desperation, unsecured credit is a double-edged sword. Yes, as we mentioned, the smart ones do not revolve loans on credit cards to avoid paying the huge interest. But as the central bank’s figures indicate, there is a trend of rising stress and delinquencies and stress in the unsecured portfolios. The lenders, especially banks, are caught on the wrong foot, twice. First, they do not earn enough interest, or revenues, from credit cards due to the first phenomenon. Second, they lose money due to defaults. Caught between the devil and deep blue sea (or a mountain of green), they step back.

For the banks, these trends, coupled with a rise in the use of credit cards, make the reward-incentive measure expensive. Perks like cashbacks and lounge accesses, which boosted the use of credit cards, are not viable. Regulatory changes, like higher capital requirements on unsecured lending, increased the cost of running card portfolios. Hence, issuers are shifting from broad, easy rewards to strict, spending-linked benefits. Many credit cards require higher spending thresholds, impose tighter caps, or exclude several categories to effectively lower the value of rewards. The economics has changed as high cashbacks exceed what banks earn per transaction, which makes them unsustainable.

Business models, and operations have undergone changes. Once the use of credit cards became normal, and the number of users expanded, it made sense for the banks and issuers to limit rewards, and reserve them for the high-value customers. There is no point to dole them out universally. As credit cards move from being acquisition tools to becoming core lending products, the era of easy, and generous rewards went out the window. But as mentioned before, there is a flip side to it, as is invariably the case. The credit boom can turn into a debt doom for people, if they roll over credit, or underestimate incomes.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

India likely to breach budgeted fiscal deficit target for FY27: BMI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's fiscal deficit is likely to breach the budgeted target for current fiscal and hit 4.5 per cent of GDP as the Government's policy response to the West Asia conflict could strain public finances, research firm BMI said on Wednesday.

The Government in 2026-27 Budget had projected a 4.3 per cent fiscal deficit, a tad lower than 4.4 per cent as per revised estimates for 2025-26. BMI also expects the Government to introduce policies to redirect critical inputs to key industries, restrain business costs and improve financial support for firms.

BMI said it also expects the Government to consider restrictions on exports of scarce inputs such as helium and sulphur — used for producing semiconductor chips. It said that since sulphur is also an important ingredient for making fertilisers, the



Government will strive to minimise disruptions to the agriculture sector, which employs 43 per cent of India's workforce.

The Government will seek to restrain cost increases for businesses affected by Strait of Hormuz's closure. To this end, the central Government has established a ₹1 lakh crore Economic Stabilisation Fund. BMI estimates this will contribute 0.1 per cent of GDP to fiscal expenditure in 2026-27.

Strait of Hormuz is a key

shipping lane through which about 20 per cent of the world's natural gas and crude oil transits.

Iran's grip on the strait has pushed oil prices sharply higher. Brent crude, the international benchmark, was trading close to \$95 per barrel on Tuesday, up more than 30 per cent since February 28, the day Israel and the US launched strikes on Iran, triggering the war.

"New Delhi will likely spend the proceeds on additional subsidies for energy

and fertiliser products. The Government's past fiscal consolidation efforts reduced expenditure on energy and fertiliser subsidies to around 1.5 per cent of India's GDP in recent years. Given the importance of energy and fertilisers to India's economy, we expect this subsidy amount to rise in FY2026/27," BMI said.

BMI had previously projected the Centre's fiscal deficit, the gap between revenue and expenditure, hitting 4.5 per cent of GDP.

"We are maintaining this forecast while acknowledging rising upside risks. The Government's policy response to the Iran conflict could strain public finances," BMI said, adding it believes the Government will continue its pursuit of long-term fiscal consolidation.

To maintain total fiscal expenditure, New Delhi might defer several energy-intensive public infrastructure projects to the next fiscal year, BMI said.

UK inflation rises as prices at pump spike after Iran war

PAN PYLAS ■ London

Inflation in the UK climbed in March after a sharp jump in prices at the petrol pump in the wake of the disruption to energy supplies caused by the Iran war, official figures showed on Wednesday.

The annual consumer price inflation rate increased to a three-month high of 3.3 per cent, from 3 per cent the previous month, according to the Office for National Statistics. The rise was in line with market expectations.

The main reason behind the inflation spike was higher motor fuel, which increased by a monthly 8.7 per cent — the largest increase since June 2022, shortly after the Russian invasion of Ukraine.

Airfares and food prices, both related to the spike in energy prices, were also higher.

Treasury chief Rachel Reeves, whose hopes over the cost-of-living have been blown off course by the



crisis in the Middle East, said this is "not our war, but it is pushing up bills for families and businesses" as a result.

The economic fallout has put paid to any expectations that the Bank of England would cut borrowing costs. Prior to the start of the war on February 28, there had been an expectation in financial markets that the bank would cut its main interest rate from 3.75 per cent given that inflation was predicted to fall back toward its 2 per cent target during the spring.

Inflation is set to rise further in coming months,

possibly to 4 per cent, as higher energy prices impact household bills.

No economist at present thinks inflation will get anywhere near the four-decade highs above 11 per cent in the wake of Russia's invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, partly because oil and gas prices have not spiked as much and partly because interest rates are higher.

But Bank of England policymakers will be keeping a beady eye on whether the evident inflation spike starts to spread through the economy, via higher wages for example. (PTI)

Need to create jobs in rural areas to reduce migration of youth: Gadkari



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Nitin Gadkari on Wednesday said there is a need to create employment opportunities in rural and tribal areas to check migration to metro cities.

Addressing the second edition of Save the Earth Conclave, Gadkari further said economic condition of farmers and workers in villages is serious.

"Youth, farmers and workers from villages are migrating to Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, Bangalore and Pune due to lack of employment opportunities there. We should create employment opportunities in villages and tribal areas," he said.

The Road Transport and Highways Minister said youth and farmers are migrating from villages out of compulsion, highlighting 10,000 farmer suicides in Vidarbha region of Maharashtra.

He also called for a transformational shift in the agriculture sector to save farmers, saying they are 'annadata' (food producer), but they should now become 'urjaadata' (energy provider).

Gadkari also made a case for increasing production of alternative fuel and bio-fuel. "We import fossil fuels worth ₹22 lakh crore, which is also causing pollution... so we need to work on increasing production of alternative fuel and bio-fuel," he said.

The sugar price is determined by Brazil, the oil price by Malaysia, the corn price by the US, and the soybean price is influenced by Argentina. "Our minimum support price (MSP) is higher than market price," he said.

Govt overhauls six-decade-old sugarcane law; seeks comments on draft by May 20

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Centre has proposed replacing the 1966 Sugarcane Control Order with a sweeping new regulatory framework that brings ethanol production, digital compliance, and a formal factory approval regime under a single law for the first time, seeking public comments by May 20.

The Union Food Ministry's draft Sugarcane (Control) Order 2026 keeps the skeleton of the old law intact — Fair and Remunerative Price rules, cane movement controls, 14-day payment deadline, and 15 per cent annual interest on delayed payments — but brings in an entirely new architecture suited to an industry that has changed



beyond recognition since the Nehru era.

The most significant departure from 1966 is the explicit integration of ethanol into the sugarcane regulatory framework. The draft expands the definition of a sugar factory to cover ethanol production from sugarcane juice, syrup, sugar, and molasses.

A concrete conversion formula has been introduced: 600 litres of ethanol will be treated as equivalent to one tonne of sugar for production calculation purposes.

Ethanol-only units that do not crush cane on their own premises are exempted from the performance bank guarantee requirement — a deliberate policy nudge to grow standalone ethanol capacity without loosening controls on integrated sugarcum-ethanol mills.

Clauses 6A through 6G introduce what the old order never had: a formal IEM-based approval process for new factories, minimum distance rules, performance bank guarantees raised to Rs 2 crore, and hard deadlines for both "effective steps" and commercial production.

Tesla launches Model YL in India

KUSHAN MITRA ■ Mumbai

Electric vehicle pioneer Tesla Motors which launched in the Indian market last year, on Wednesday launched their latest offering on the market, the long-wheelbase version of the Model Y.

The Model YL will be priced at ₹61.99 lakh. The Model Y, which has been the world's best selling car for three years continuously was introduced as a long-wheelbase variant for the Chinese market last year.

The Model YL will be offered as a six seater in India. It will feature all-wheel drive with dual motors and a certified range of 681 kilometres. It will be the most affordable three-row luxury SUV on the Indian market as well as being significantly cheaper than the standard Model Y Long-Range. It remains to be seen whether Tesla India will continue to sell their earlier launched models in India.

Speaking to the assembled media, Sharad Aggarwal, Country Head, Tesla India said that the company was also expanding their service network in the coming months adding centers in



Ahmedabad, Bengaluru, Chennai and Hyderabad after opening a centre in Pune recently.

"Most problems can be fixed by over-the-air updates but we realise that consumers need the comfort of a nearby service centre." And while Tesla will expand their charging network, Aggarwal highlighted that the company will continue with their strategy of online sales, as the

company can 'deliver anywhere' and vehicles have been delivered to 21 States in India already

It was also disclosed that Tesla will be potentially launching their energy business in India which they feel will play a major role in the Artificial Intelligence future. Tesla's humanoid robot Optimus is also potentially going to be offered in India.

Markets cautious worldwide as fragile US-Iran ceasefire keeps investors on edge

YURI KAGEYAMAAP
■ Tokyo

Global shares were mixed in cautious trading on Wednesday, as investors watched for next steps in the US-Iran conflict after President Donald Trump extended a ceasefire that was set to expire.

France's CAC 40 slipped 0.2 per cent in early trading to 8,221.18, while the German DAX inched down less than 0.1 per cent to 24,256.40. Britain's FTSE 100 was virtually unchanged at 10,497.60.

US futures were set to drift higher with Dow futures up 0.4 per cent at 49,509.00. S&P 500 futures rose 0.4 per

Trump imposed after returning to office last year.

Australia's S&P/ASX 200 declined 1.2 per cent to 8,843.60. South Korea's Kospi added 0.5 per cent to 6,417.93. Hong Kong's Hang Seng lost 1.2 per cent to 26,163.24, while the Shanghai Composite gained 0.5 per cent to 4,106.26. Oil prices have been wavering. In Asian trading Wednesday, benchmark US crude fell at first but later rose 50 cents to \$90.17 a barrel. Brent crude, the international standard, gained 81 cents to \$99.29.

The moves were milder than the vicious swings that rocked Wall Street earlier in the war, when the price for



cent to 7,131.00. Inflation in the UK climbed in March after a sharp jump in prices at the pump in the wake of the disruption to energy supplies caused by the Iran war, official figures showed on Wednesday. In Asian trading, Japan's benchmark Nikkei 225 rose 0.4 per cent to finish at 59,585.86.

The Government reported a trade deficit of 1.7 trillion yen (\$10.7 billion) in the fiscal year that ended in March, the fifth straight fiscal year of deficits.

However, exports jumped nearly 11.7 per cent in March and imports rose almost 10.9 per cent in a sign that manufacturers may be bouncing back from the shocks of higher tariffs

a barrel of Brent crude briefly topped \$119 and the S&P 500 dropped nearly 10 per cent below its prior all-time high. Much of the tension in financial markets has focused on what will happen to the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow waterway off Iran's coast that oil tankers use to exit the Persian Gulf.

Japan, for instance, imports just about all its oil, and much of it previously came through the strait. The Government has released its oil reserves and is working on alternative routes.

US Vice President JD Vance called off a trip to Pakistan, where he was expected to lead US negotiators in talks with Iran to extend the ceasefire. (PTI)

FSIB invites application from private sector for selection of public sector banks' EDs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

FSIB, the headhunter for directors of State-owned banks and financial institutions, has invited applications from eligible candidates, including those from the private sector, for the appointment of executive directors of nationalised banks during the current financial year.

Inclusion of candidates from the private sector is a departure from the set procedure, and this is the first time that the Financial Services Institutions Bureau (FSIB) would consider them

for selection for more than half a dozen vacancies of EDs expected to be created during the current financial year.

As per the eligibility criteria announced by FSIB, the applicant from the private sector should have at least 18 years of experience, with 12 years of banking experience, including 3 years at the highest level below board level (to be held on a substantive basis).

Candidates who are not from nationalised banks shall be considered as private candidates, FSIB said in a public notice. Private candidates are required to provide an



organogram of the bank in which they have the highest level of experience below board level, clearly indicating their position in the organisation hierarchy, it said,

adding that the organogram(s) should be submitted along with the resume. With respect to candidates from public sector banks, it said, the applicant

Stock markets snap 3-day rally; Sensex tumbles 757 pts dragged by IT shares, jump in oil prices

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

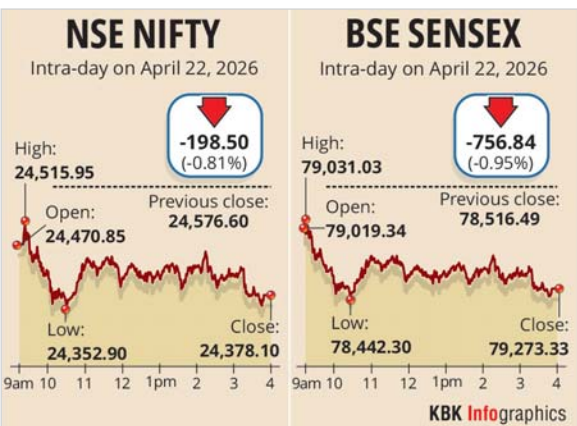
Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty tumbled nearly 1 per cent on Wednesday, snapping a three-day gaining streak due to heavy selling in IT stocks and an uptick in crude oil prices.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 756.84 points or 0.95 per cent to settle at 78,516.49. During the day, it slumped 831.03 points or 1.04 per cent to 78,442.30.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 198.50 points or 0.81 per cent to end at 24,378.10.

Foreign fund outflows and fears of prolonged instability in West Asia also dented market sentiment.

Among 30-Sensex firms, HCL Tech tumbled the most by 10.85 per cent after its March quarter earnings failed to cheer investors. HCL Tech reported a 4.20 per cent on-year rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 4,488 crore for the March quarter, even as the management flagged a highly



volatile demand environment shadowed by tariffs and softened discretionary spends, giving a FY27 growth guidance of 1-4 per cent.

Infosys, Mahindra & Mahindra, Tata Consultancy Services, Tech Mahindra and ICICI Bank were also among the major laggards.

Hindustan Unilever, NTPC, Eternal and Trent were among the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 1.26 per cent higher at \$99.72 per barrel. "Indian equity markets traded with a clear

negative bias throughout the session, weighed down by persistent geopolitical tensions in the Middle East and the continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Despite the ceasefire extension, the continued US blockade and the unresolved situation in the Strait of Hormuz kept energy markets elevated," Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹1,918.99

crore on Tuesday, according to exchange data.

"The primary trigger behind today's weakness was the resurgence of geopolitical uncertainty. Reports of stalled US-Iran negotiations have reignited concerns over prolonged instability in West Asia, keeping risk appetite in check. This has also supported elevated crude oil prices, adding pressure on inflation expectations and currency stability," Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Shanghai's SSE Composite index ended in positive territory, while Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended lower. Markets in Europe were trading on a mixed note. US markets ended lower on Tuesday.

On Tuesday, the Sensex jumped 753.03 points or 0.96 per cent to settle at 79,273.33. The Nifty climbed 211.75 points or 0.87 per cent to end at 24,576.60.

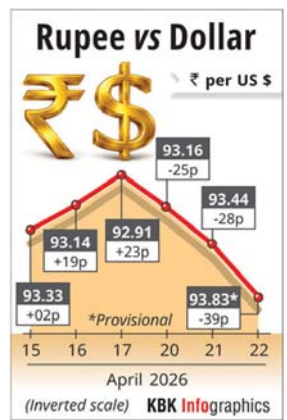
Rupee nears 94/USD level; settles 39 paise lower

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

The rupee weakened for the third straight session, losing 39 paise to settle at 93.83 (provisional) against the US dollar on Wednesday as uncertainty on US-Iran peace talks eroded hopes of easing West Asia conflict and set crude oil prices on fire. Intense selling in domestic equity markets and sustained outflow of foreign capital also weighed on the Indian currency, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 93.69 and touched an intraday low of 93.87 against the greenback during the session, nearing the 94 level it reached for the first time on March 23. The domestic unit finally ended the session at 93.83 (provisional) against the dollar, registering a loss of 39 paise from the previous close.

On Tuesday, the rupee plunged 28 paise to settle at 93.44 against the US dollar, a day after losing 25 paise on Monday. The currency had gained 47 paise in the preceding two sessions.



Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst at Mirae Asset Sharekhan, said the rupee declined on an overnight surge in crude oil prices and uncertainty over US-Iran talks.

He further said that the rupee is expected to trade with a negative bias amid FII outflow pressure. "However, softening of the US dollar may prevent a sharp fall in the rupee. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹93.60 to ₹94.20."

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, went down 0.07 per cent to 98.15.

Israel stands with India against terror: FM Gideon

HARINDER MISHRA
Jerusalem

Vowing to fight against terrorism "resolutely" in "all its forms", Israel on Wednesday expressed solidarity with grieving India on the first anniversary of the dastardly Pahalgam attack, which claimed the lives of 26 people on April 22 last year.

"On behalf of the State of Israel, on one year to the Pahalgam terror attack, we honour the memory of the innocent lives lost and stand with their families in grief," Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar wrote on X.

"Israel remains resolute and unwavering in its fight against terrorism in all its forms. Together with India, we will continue to strengthen our



Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Sa'ar

cooperation to confront this threat with determination and to advance peace, security, and stability", Sa'ar emphasised.

Earlier on Wednesday, Israel's Ambassador to India, Reuven Azar, in a video message also paid tributes to the 26 innocent victims of the terror attack

saying that the "pain is deeply familiar" and that "terror has no borders."

Pakistan-based terror group Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) carried out the attack at Pahalgam in Jammu and Kashmir on this day last year, killing 26 people, mostly tourists from across India. (PTI)

EU EXPRESSES SOLIDARITY WITH INDIA ON PAHALGAM ATTACK

London. The European Union (EU) on Wednesday expressed solidarity with the people of India in commemoration of the first anniversary of the "heinous terrorist attack" in Pahalgam, which claimed the lives of 26 people on April 22 last year. In a statement on behalf of the 27-member economic bloc, the EU reiterated its condemnation of terrorism in all its forms. "On the commemoration day of the heinous terrorist attack in Pahalgam, the European Union and its 27 Member States stand in solidarity with the people of India in remembrance of the innocent victims murdered one year ago," reads the EU statement.

"Together with their families and the Indian authorities, we honour their memory. We reiterate our outright condemnation of terrorism in all its forms, which can never be justified," it stated. The British High Commission in

New Delhi also issued a statement on social media in tribute to the lives lost and condemning all acts of terror.

It stated: "Today, we mark one year since the horrific terrorist attack in Pahalgam. We pay our respects to the victims, and our thoughts remain with everyone affected. "The UK condemns terrorism in all its forms. We remain committed to working with partners to secure peace and security." Pakistan-based terror group Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) carried out the attack at Pahalgam in Jammu and Kashmir on this day last year, killing 26 people, mostly tourists from across India. After the attack, India carried out a retaliatory military offensive against Pakistan named Operation Sindoor, in which Indian armed forces destroyed military and terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).

Real need for Security Council reform: UNSG candidate Bachelet

YOSHITA SINGH
United Nations

UN Secretary General candidate Michelle Bachelet said there is a "real need" for Security Council reform and greater representation in both permanent and non-permanent categories, vowing to push efforts towards achieving it.

Bachelet, the former Chilean president, is one of the four candidates currently in the fray to be the next Secretary General of the United Nations.

The current UN chief, Antonio Guterres, completes his tenure on December 31, after having served two consecutive five-year terms as the world's top diplomat. "I

think it's a real need for a reform of the Security Council," Bachelet said here Tuesday in response to a question by PTI on the long-pending UNSC reforms and developing countries like India sitting at the powerful table as permanent members to reflect current global realities.

India has been at the forefront of years-long efforts calling for reform of the Security Council, including expansion in both its permanent and non-permanent categories, saying the 15-nation Council, founded in 1945, is not fit for purpose in the 21st Century and does not reflect contemporary geopolitical realities. New Delhi has consistently underscored



that it rightly deserves a permanent seat at the horse-shoe table. Bachelet said reforming the Security Council is a decision to be taken by UN member states.

"But I think there is an opportunity," she said, referring to the Pact of the Future, adopted by world leaders in 2024, that gave a strong

clarion call to reform the 15-nation body. Bachelet, who is also the former United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights, said when people around the world look at the UN, they see the Security Council, they see a body

"that is not solving the problem, that is paralysed", has deadlocks on issues that "really means the suffering of millions of people". She stressed that while the UN member states will decide how the Security Council is reformed, but "to really be able to be different", the Council "needs to have representation of member states who are not represented there — as permanent member or non-permanent members as well, because that's the only possibility to sort of solve the deadlock, the blockage that's there".

Bachelet said that while it sounds too much, there won't be hope for the multilateral system if the Security Council is not reformed. (PTI)

EU envoys meet over Ukraine loan delay

LORNE COOK
Brussels

European Union envoys gathered on Wednesday with the majority cautiously optimistic that a massive loan to help meet Ukraine's military and financial needs for the next two years may soon be approved after months of deadlock.

At a meeting in Brussels, the envoys assessed whether Hungary might lift its veto on the 90-billion-euro (\$106 billion) loan package, which Ukraine desperately needs to prop up its war-ravaged economy and help keep Russian forces at bay.

Hungary has insisted that it must start receiving supplies of Russian oil again via Ukraine before it will unblock the funds. Hungary and Slovakia rely on Russian oil to meet their energy needs.

They have both accused Ukraine of failing to repair a damaged pipeline that ships the oil. Ukraine and most of its European backers oppose imports of Russian oil, which have helped to fund President Vladimir Putin's war, now in

its fifth year. In a post on social media, President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Tuesday that Ukraine has now completed repairs on the Druzhba pipeline.

He said it "was damaged by a Russian strike" but "the pipeline can resume operation." But outgoing Hungarian Prime Minister Viktor Orban has signalled that he would only approve the Ukraine loans once the oil starts flowing again, so the envoys are awaiting a clear signal from Budapest that his veto will be lifted.

Orban, who has repeatedly blocked EU aid to Ukraine, lost an election on April 12 and is due to leave office next month, to be replaced by the pro-European opposition leader Peter Magyar.

Cyprus, which currently holds the EU's rotating presidency, intends to launch a written procedure to approve the final piece of the puzzle in the loan package. That would require Hungary or any other objecting nation to state in writing why they oppose it. (AP)



Cuban exiles have renewed hope and fears over claims on property seized long ago

JOSHUA GOODMAN
Miami

Deeply ingrained in Raul Valdes-Fauli's family lore is the November 1960 day when an agent of Fidel Castro's revolution showed up at his family's Pedrosa Bank in Havana, with a machine gun, and demanded they leave.

Calling his father and uncle gusanos - or worms, a Spanish-language term coined by Castro to denigrate those fleeing the island — the agent seized the bank and in an instant dispos-



sessed a family that arrived from Spain in the 16th century. "They told them this was

now the people's bank," said Valdes-Fauli, an attorney and former mayor of the Miami suburb of Coral Gables.

"They couldn't even take family pictures off the walls of their office." Seven decades later such traumatic episodes are resurfacing with urgency, as President Donald Trump's threats of military intervention, backed by a naval blockade of fuel shipments that has brought the island's already-anemic economy to its knees, have spawned negotiations between Washington and Havana. Many Cuban Americans are convinced that 2026 could - finally - be the year of regime change on the communist-run island.

But that cautious optimism among exiles is tempered by concern they could be cut out.

Their nightmare scenario: a repeat of what happened recently in Venezuela, where Trump ousted Nicolas Maduro only to join forces with his former allies in a partnership where demands for democracy are taking a back seat to oil industry deal-making. "I hope that he doesn't do what he did in Venezuela, which is keep the thieves in power," said Valdes-Fauli, who married a Venezuelan. (AP)

Berlin Zoo tour brings joy to dementia patients



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Berlin

Christel Krueger peered through thick glass and murky water at the Berlin Zoo, staring in awe at a mother hippopotamus and her child sleeping on a sandbar.

Krueger, 86, and her daughter were on a specialised zoo tour last month for people who live with dementia that was organised by Malteser Deutschland, part of the international Catholic aid organisation Malteser Order of Malta.

On the tour with Krueger, Ingrid Barkow watched from her wheelchair as the elephants roamed their habitat, while Monika Jansen balanced on her tiptoes to get a better view of a rhinoceros. "When I get home, I'll still be

thinking about it," said Jansen, 85. "Maybe even at night, while I'm sleeping and dreaming about it."

The three women are among roughly 1.6 million people living with dementia in Germany, according to the Office of the National Dementia Strategy. The figure is expected to rise to 2.8 million by 2050.

Museums and other cultural institutions across the globe have added specialised, barrier-free tours and guides to their repertoire in recent years, some made possible by advances in technology.

These include sign-language tours for people who are deaf and hard of hearing, touch-based events for those with blindness or low vision and programmes for people on the autism spectrum.

Pope visiting one of Equatorial Guinea's notorious prisons



ASSOCIATED PRESS
Malabo

Pope Leo XIV is visiting one of Equatorial Guinea's notorious prisons Wednesday, drawing attention to human rights abuses that campaigners have denounced for years and especially after the US began deporting third-country migrants. Leo's visit to the prison in Bata, the central African country's port city, continues the tradition of Pope Francis, who made prison visits a priority of his pontificate. Francis' aim was to give prisoners hope and to remind them the church was with them, while also shining

a spotlight on judicial abuses, overcrowding and other injustices. The visit caps Leo's last full day in Africa, rounding out a marathon 11-day, four-nation tour that took him from Algeria in the north to Angola in the south, with Cameroon in between.

He was due to open the day with a Mass in Mongomo, in the far east, before arriving in Bata, the country's most populous city on the coast. Also on the agenda was a moment of prayer at a memorial to victims of a 2021 explosion in a military barracks in Bata that has been blamed on negligence.



Submarine Rescue Vessel of the Indian Navy arrived at the port of Colombo, Sri Lanka to participate in the 4th edition of IN-SLN DIVEX 2026

Air China resumes Delhi-Beijing non-stop flight

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Air China has resumed its non-stop Delhi-Beijing flight, reconnecting the flight services between the two capitals. With the resumption of the Delhi-Beijing flight, air connectivity between several cities of the two countries, disrupted since 2020 due to COVID-19 and then the military standoff in Eastern Ladakh, has been restored.

Air China has resumed non-stop flights connecting Beijing and Delhi on Tuesday, the airline said on its Facebook account.

The Beijing-Delhi flights will operate on Tuesdays, Fridays and Sundays, using Airbus A330-200/300 aircraft, the announcement said. On April 18, China Eastern Airlines resumed its direct flight between Kunming, China's southwestern Yunnan Province,



and Kolkata, India.

It was the carrier's latest expansion of its China-India route network following the resumption of the Shanghai-Delhi route in November 2025. China Eastern Airlines said that the route, with six weekly round-trip flights using Boeing 737 aircraft, will add more convenience to travellers between the two countries. India's airlines too are now operating flights to Chinese cities.

IndiGo launched daily

direct flights between Kolkata and Shanghai on March 29. Earlier, IndiGo resumed the Kolkata-Guangzhou route and launched the Delhi-Guangzhou route.

With the introduction of the Kolkata-Shanghai route, IndiGo said it will continue to enrich travel options between China and India, effectively meeting the growing demand for economic, trade, and tourism exchanges between the world's two most populous

nations, China's state-run Global Times reported.

According to the latest operational data for April, IndiGo has maintained an overall passenger load factor between 68 per cent and 85 per cent on multiple China-India routes. Popular routes such as Delhi-Guangzhou and Kolkata-Guangzhou have shown particularly outstanding performances, reflecting a stable and positive operational trend, the report said.

More airlines from both sides are increasing their services, which have positive significance for further consolidating the momentum of bilateral ties.

It also reflects India's further pragmatic adjustments, including in its China policy, Qian Feng, director of the Research Department at Tsinghua University's National Strategy Institute, told the Global Times. (PTI)



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No: **97/MD** /OSCSC Ltd., Date **21.04.2026**

CORRIGENDUM

Ref: Request for Proposal (RFP) Advt. No. 6414/OSCSC Ltd., Date: 30/03/2026

With reference to the Request for Proposal published vide RFP Advt. No. 6414/OSCSC Ltd. Dated 30/03/2026 for 'Selection of Service Provider for e-Auction Platform and Related Support Services for Paddy and Rice', the last Date and time for submission of Proposal is hereby extended till 28/04/2026 at 17:00 Hours through online at www.tendersodisha.gov.in. Interested bidders may refer to the details of the corrigendum published in the websites www.foododisha.in, www.oscsc.in and www.tendersodisha.gov.in.

-sd/-
Managing Director
Odisha State Civil Supplies Corporation Limited

OIPR-7001/7002/1/2627/0002

Sugor Tso : An Alpine Lake system of Upper Siang



COL DIBYA SHANKAR BHATTACHARYA (RETD)

Sugor Tso is a geographically significant high altitude lake system located in the remote mountains of Arunachal Pradesh. Despite its remoteness, Sugor Tso plays a crucial role in the local hydrology and sustenance of nearby communities, while also representing the complex geological and ecological processes that define the mountainous region of Arunachal Pradesh.

Sugor Tso is located in the Upper Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh and is characterised by rugged mountainous terrain and deep valleys. The precise geographical location of Sugor Tso places it within the upper reaches of the Siang river basin in the Eastern Himalayan region, an area which is part of a highly sensitive and ecologically rich zone, known for its steep gradients,

heavy rainfall, and dense vegetation at lower altitudes, transitioning into alpine conditions at higher elevations.

Characteristics of Sugor Tso

Sugor Tso is not a single water body but a dual lake system, comprising of Upper Sugor Tso and Sugor Tso. These lakes are hydrologically connected and originate from the Sugor stream, which serves as the primary source feeding the system. The naming of the lakes is directly derived from this stream, reflecting a common pattern in Himalayan geography where water bodies are named after their feeder systems.

Sugor Tso is situated within the Eastern Himalayan biodiversity hotspot, a region known for its rich and diverse ecosystems. Although specific ecological studies on the lake are limited, its environment supports a range of flora and fauna adapted to high altitude and humid mountain conditions. The lakes are situated in a high relief mountainous environment, where natural depressions formed by geological and erosional processes collect water from streams,

melted snow, precipitation and the inflow of surrounding catchment areas.

Significance of Sugor Tso

One of the most important aspects of Sugor Tso is its role as a primary water source for the villages in proximity, specifically Bidak and Gelemo. In remote mountainous regions where infrastructure is minimal and groundwater extraction is not feasible, surface water bodies such as lakes and streams are essential for survival. The Sugor Tso lake caters to the domestic water needs of the local populace as also in small scale agriculture and in livestock rearing. It's reliability as a water source makes it a vital component of the local livelihood system, especially to the Monpa, Tagin, and Adi tribes.

For these tribal communities, lakes are part of a living landscape that support both livelihood and their cultural identity, which is often associated with nature centric beliefs and an innate respect for environmental balance. The presence of a stable freshwater system enhances local biodiversity by providing habitat and sustaining



vegetation in the surrounding areas. Such ecosystems are highly sensitive to environmental changes, making conservation and sustainable use particularly important.

Accessibility

Access to Sugor Tso is challenging due

to its remote location and rugged terrain. The Upper Siang district of Arunachal Pradesh itself is sparsely connected, with travel typically involving long road journeys through mountainous routes, followed by movement into the interior regions which may require trekking as well as possession

of the necessary permits. The lack of infrastructure, unpredictable weather, and high-altitude conditions make travel to the lake suitable only for well-prepared individuals, often with local guidance.

Conclusion

In conclusion, Sugor Tso stands out due to its dual lake structure, stream based origin, and relevance to local communities. Unlike more prominent Himalayan lakes that attract tourism or large-scale research attention, Sugor Tso remains largely unrecognised which has preserved its natural state underscoring the vast number of remotely located natural features of Arunachal Pradesh. Its significance lies not only in its geographical and ecological characteristics but also in its functional role that it plays within the local environment, exemplifying how small, natural systems can sustain human life and communities as well as play a vital role in the ecological balance of mountainous terrains.

The author is a well-known Army veteran, strategic affairs expert and a practicing advocate in Gauhati High Court

ITC's social impact scale with over 200 'Multi-verse' partnerships

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Recognising that systemic change demands decisive action, ITC Limited has consciously nurtured and orchestrated a multi-stakeholder ecosystem of over 200 partners across public and private domains as part of Corporate Social Responsibility.

The partnership-led approach enables ITC to scale and deepen its sustainability and social initiatives, embedding them within institutions, communities and public systems. As a part of its 4P strategy, with a focus on Public-Private-People-Partnerships, ITC has forged over 98 PPPs and 25+ Knowledge Partnerships till date and works with 110+ implementing agencies.

According to a Press release, through this 'Multi-verse' of partnerships, spanning government and allied institutions, grassroot agencies, civil society organisations, technical



institutes, think tanks, corporate partners, and academic bodies – ITC brings together resources, expertise and delivery capabilities in a seamless and coordinated manner. This time-tested model assumes relevance in the context of the Earth Day theme for 2026.

Within its programme catchments, ITC plays the role of a primary facilitator, accountable for programme design and delivery, funding, governance systems and processes, monitoring and evaluation for impacts and outcomes, while ensuring that communities remain at the heart of every intervention.

This approach is reinforced by over 29,700 empowered grassroot institutions, including the Water User Groups, Farmer Producer Organisations, Vannikaran Sanghas (communities to promote social

forestry), Charagah Vikas Samitis (communities to protect and manage common grazing lands), Agri-Business Centres, School Development Management Committees, Self-Help Groups, Mohalla Committees & Mothers Groups.

"A defining feature of ITC's social investments programme - Mission Sunehra Kal – is designing interventions with scale and outcome intentionality through multi-dimensional collaborations. ITC follows a structured framework that moves initiatives from prototype to pilot and then to scale. Once collaborative interventions demonstrate measurable outcomes, they are amplified through public-private-partnerships, or multiplied through collaboratives. This systematic approach ensures that interventions are not only effective but also replicable across larger populations and more geographies," said Prabhakar Lingareddy, Executive Vice President and Head - Social Investments, ITC Limited.



DG CRPF GP Singh, IPS, visited Antla in Mohanpur, West Medinipur following reports of group clashes.

IndianOil Refineries HQ hosts Public Sector Month Talk on India's global ascent



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As part of ongoing Public Sector Month celebrations, Arvind Kumar, Director (Refineries), IndianOil, led a special session for the senior leadership team, featuring an address by former Ambassador Deepak Vohra.

Dr Vohra delivered a compelling talk on "The Jaamvant Effect: How India Becomes Bharat," underscoring India's rise as a global power driven by

strong economic fundamentals, digital advancement, and strategic capabilities. He highlighted the importance of unlocking the nation's full potential on its journey towards a Viksit Bharat. Reaffirming Indian Oil's role in nation-building, Kumar emphasised the Company's unwavering commitment to energy security, ensuring uninterrupted availability of petroleum products even amid global supply disruptions.

Rohit Kumar appointed as President India Campus Business



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

MSM Unify, the global technology-driven education platform, has appointed Rohit Kumar as Founding Member & President of India Campus Business. The appointment signals a decisive step in company's ambition to deepen its presence within India's higher education ecosystem one of the fastest-evolving in the world. Kumar will lead MSM Unify's India Business vertical with end-to-end responsibility for institutional partnerships, campus engagement strategy and domestic growth.

Sanjay Laul, Founder, MSM Unify, said Rohit brings exactly the kind of entrepreneurial energy that this role demands.

DAILY SUDOKU

			8			9	7	
		2						4
7				3	1	2		
	3			1		4		7
	7						1	
8		1		9			2	
		9	3	8				2
3						5		
	8	5			9			

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

No. SS2120 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★★

SOLUTION (22.04.26)								
2	6	7	5	3	8	9	4	1
9	3	1	6	7	4	5	2	8
4	8	5	1	9	2	7	3	6
5	9	8	4	2	7	6	1	3
3	2	6	8	5	1	4	9	7
1	7	4	9	6	3	8	5	2
7	5	3	2	4	6	1	8	9
6	1	9	3	8	5	2	7	4
8	4	2	7	1	9	3	6	5

No. SS2119 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

DOUBLE CROSSWORD THURSDAY | APRIL 23, 2026

1	2		3	4		5		6	7		8	
					9							
10									11			
13			14							15		16
17									18			
20	21								22		23	
24												
27										28		
30												

- ACROSS**
- 1 An accident on court? (5)
 - 6 Religious treatment for broken lamps (5)
 - 9 To find the motorway clear, perhaps, is a marvel! (7)
 - 10 In the Muslim world, one encounters something possibly grand (5)
 - 11 A drawback for Oscar, say? (5)
 - 12 Killed off the vice around Los Angeles (5)
 - 13 Possibly Alf has clay to mould, but you may not believe it (7)
 - 15 Just a hint of a green salad fruit? (3)
 - 17 There's little work for us in music! (4)
 - 18 They're heard to give a blockhead disturbed sleep (6)
 - 19 Set out to be a warm-hearted, bright

- DOWN**
- 2 An accident messed up his map (6)
 - 3 Those little things at the laundry (6)
 - 4 That chap I'm after at the hotel (3)
 - 5 A witticism from aunt? (5)
 - 6 Clearly making a drama out of nothing, possibly (7)
 - 7 Being stitched up makes little difference to Sean (4)
 - 8 Beat up at last! (6)
 - 12 It's alarming, Oscar losing his head and coming to a sticky end! (5)
 - 13 Forward a letter or two (5)
 - 14 Tempted by a bit of luck on the red (5)

- fellow (5)
- 20 Is the right number (6)
- 22 Figure to have a great time with a girl (4)
- 24 Deceived in a way that's a bit shady (3)
- 25 Michael took a girl round the drama school (7)
- 26 A flat can lead to such an accident (5)
- 27 Place for high living on a low income? (5)
- 28 Fail to stand out in civil disobedience (3-2)
- 29 Everybody hastened out of the plant (7)
- 30 To speak raspily sounds great (5)
- 31 Taking a rest from veracity (5)

- 15 Allowed to contribute to police deductions (5)
- 16 Try the Evening Standard, for instance (5)
- 18 Alban's everyday aspect (5)
- 19 Shiftily cheat at being a diplomat (7)
- 21 In a restaurant, a helpful line in cheap drink? (6)
- 22 Futility of a fictitious fair (6)
- 23 Fair part of a train wrecked going round a loop line (6)
- 25 Mistake made by the soccer people last month (5)
- 26 Is within twelve inches (thus handy)? (4)
- 28 Note how sunny he is! (3)

Circular Economy presents transformative opportunities across value chain: Jitendra Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State (Independent) Dr Jitendra Singh on Monday emphasised that recycling is emerging as a major economic driver for startups and MSMEs, and is no longer confined to large business houses. Addressing the RECEIC Global Symposium on 'Resource Efficiency and Circular Economy: Co-creating Circular Future – Policy, Partnerships and Implementation Pathways', the Minister highlighted that circular economy presents a transformative opportunity across the value chain, from grassroots entrepreneurs to large industries.

"Recycling is not going to be the prerogative of big business houses alone. It will be a source of economy for all of us and a very strong avenue for startups and MSMEs," added Dr Singh.

Singh underscored that the government has opened up vir-



tually every sector, including space and nuclear, to private participation, and called upon industry to adopt a proactive mindset. "Government is a facilitator. The private sector must now step forward with confidence and innovation," he added.

Dr Singh noted that the government has generated over ₹4,000 crore in the past five years through systematic disposal of scrap, including e-waste, under a cleanliness campaign launched in October 2021. "The results demonstrate that there is economic value in every form of waste," he stated.

Neelesh Sah, Joint Secretary,

Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC), Govt of India highlighted the impact of India's Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) framework. Introduced in 2016 and digitised in 2022-23, the framework has seen strong participation, with nearly 75,000 producers, importers and brand owners and around 5,000 recyclers registered across platforms.

Dr Jitendra Kumar, Managing Director, Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC), highlighted the need to re-evaluate development pathways through the lens of sustainability and circularity.

Manish Sharma, Chair, RECEIC Steering Committee, stated that the 60-member industry coalition is working through five thematic working groups—packaging, material transition, used oil circularity, textiles and apparel, and dry cell batteries—with pilot projects underway to drive on-ground implementation.

Heat-resistant shelters replaces plastic sheets after devastating Lucknow slum fire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

A major fire that tore through Vikas Nagar in Lucknow on April 15 has left a trail of destruction, displacing over 1,000 people and exposing the vulnerability of informal settlements to recurring disasters.

The blaze broke out in the afternoon in the densely populated locality, home largely to migrant and daily wage workers. Fanned by close-packed structures and narrow lanes, the fire spread rapidly from one makeshift dwelling to another, leaving residents with little time to salvage their belongings. Eyewitnesses reported multiple explosions during the incident as LPG cylinders caught fire, intensifying the flames and complicating firefighting efforts.

By the time the situation was brought under control, nearly



300 homes had been reduced to ashes. The tragedy also claimed the lives of two young children. In the aftermath, Jodhpur-based non-profit True Hope Foundation has initiated the installation of 100 heat-resistant and waterproof shelters, offering a more secure alternative to the plastic sheets initially used by displaced families.

Early relief efforts by authorities and local groups focused on distributing food and temporary coverings. However, with temperatures in the city crossing 40°C, the plastic tents proved inadequate, offering little insulation from the heat while remain-

ing highly flammable. To address these concerns, the foundation has introduced specially designed 10x20 ft shelters built with heat-reflective materials and waterproof coatings. These structures aim to provide safer and more climate-resilient temporary housing.

"The goal is to move beyond short-term fixes," said Dhaval Darji. "These families have lost everything. While they wait for permanent rehabilitation, they need shelters that can withstand the current climate and provide a baseline of safety and dignity," he added.

District officials have verified around 260 affected families residing on PWD-owned land in Sectors 11 and 12. The state government has announced ex-gratia compensation of ₹4 lakh to the families of the deceased and distributed ration kits to survivors.

BRIEFLY

Lens reaches French Cup final



Florian Thauvin scored from the penalty spot and provided an assist as Lens kept its domestic-double hopes alive by beating Toulouse 4-1 on Tuesday to reach the French Cup final.

Thauvin put Lens ahead in the ninth minute with a well-taken penalty without a run-up and soon after set up Allan Saint-Maximin.

Santiago Hidalgo scored for Toulouse in the 21st minute before defender Matthieu Udol restored the two-goal lead from close range before the interval.

Adrien Thomasson capped Lens' win in the 74th minute.

Lens will face the winner of Wednesday's semifinal between Strasbourg and Nice.

Inter comes back from 2 goals down to beat Como and reach Italian Cup final



Inter Milan's pursuit of a sweep of the Italian league and Cup titles is still alive.

The Serie A leader came back from two goals down for a decisive 3-2 win over Como in the second leg of the Italian Cup semifinals on Tuesday.

Hakan Calhanoglu scored twice and Petar Susic had the winner in the 89th minute after Martin Baturina and Como captain Lucas Da Cunha scored either side of halftime.

The first leg ended 0-0.

Atalanta hosts Lazio in the other semifinal on Wednesday after a 2-2 draw in the first leg.

The final is scheduled for May 13.

Meanwhile, Inter could clinch the Serie A title as soon as this weekend.

SAFF Women's Championship: India Grouped with Bangladesh, Maldives



The Indian women's football team has been drawn alongside Bangladesh and the Maldives in Group B of the SAFF Women's Championship to be held in Margao, Goa, from May 25 to June 6.

Group A features Nepal, Sri Lanka and Bhutan.

The top two teams from each group will advance to the semifinals, according to the draw conducted at the SAFF Secretariat in Dhaka on Wednesday.

Pakistan has decided not to send its team.

This will be the second time India is hosting the SAFF Women's Championship, after the 2016 edition in Siliguri, West Bengal, where India won their fourth title.

It will also be the second time that Goa will stage a SAFF tournament. The men's championship of 1999 was also held at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, where India won the title, defeating Bangladesh in the final.

Shaurya Binu leads in IGPL Invitational Congo

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Lubumbashi (Congo)

Young Shaurya Binu continued his fine run in the African Swing, carding a brilliant nine-under 64 to move atop the leaderboard after two rounds at the AM Green IGPL Invitational Congo.

The 21-year-old Binu, who is balancing his academics with golf and has recorded two top-10 finishes on the African Swing over the past two weeks, opened with a one-under 72 in the first round at the Par-73 Golf Club Lubumbashi. He then produced a stunning nine-under in the second round to move to 10-under after 36 holes, giving him a two-shot lead over four players.

The four player pack behind him includes first round co-leaders Mannat Brar (67-71) and Tushar Pannu (67-71), last week's winner Udayan Mane (70-68) and Aryan Roopa Anand (71-67), all at eight under after two days.

Teeing off from the first, Binu, who has been in strong



form with a seventh place finish in Mauritius and a tied fourth in Joburg, made a steady start before opening his birdie account on the par four fourth.

He then surged with three straight birdies from the sixth and capped the run with an eagle on the ninth to turn in six under.

He held steady with five pars on the back nine before

Zelvia beats Shabab Al-Ahli 1-0 to reach Asian Champions League final

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jeddah

Japan's Machida Zelvia advanced to the final of the Asian Champions League Elite by beating Shabab Al-Ahli of the United Arab Emirates 1-0 on Tuesday.

Yuki Soma's first-half goal secured a meeting with defending champion Al-Ahli Saudi on Saturday in Jeddah.

Soma struck in the 12th minute, pouncing on a weak back pass from defender Bogdan Planic to shoot past goalkeeper Hamad Al-Meqbaali. Kauan Santos nearly equalized 10 minutes before halftime when he hit the crossbar with a powerful effort from outside the area.

In the 92nd minute, Guilherme Bala appeared to have forced extra time with



a long-range strike, but the goal was disallowed after a lengthy VAR review because play restarted before Machida completed a substitution.

Machida is aiming to emulate the Western Sydney Wanderers' performance in 2014 of winning the continental club title on debut.

On Monday, Al-Ahli Saudi beat Vissel Kobe 2-1 to reach its second straight final. The Jeddah-based club beat Kawasaki Frontale of Japan 2-0 in the 2025 final in May of last year in front of 60,000 home fans at King Abdullah Sports City Stadium.

All knockout-stage matches this month have been played in Jeddah after Western Zone 2026 playoffs were postponed in March because of the war in the Middle East.

Leicester relegated to third division



JAMES ROBSON ■ London

Former Premier League champion Leicester will be playing in the third tier of English soccer next season.

Leicester, which sealed the unlikely title win of the Premier League era in 2016 at odds of 5,000-1, needed a victory Tuesday to maintain hope of avoiding relegation but drew 2-2 with Hull.

The midlands club, which also won the FA Cup in 2021 and played in England's top flight last season, is second to last in the second-tier Championship.

In a statement to fans, Leicester chairman Aiyawatt Srivaddhanaprabha, said responsibility sat with him.

"There are no excuses," he said. "We have experienced the highest highs and now the lowest lows, and the pain is shared by all of us. I am truly sorry for the disappointment we have caused."

Relegation comes after Leicester was docked six points in February for breaching the English Football League's financial rules when it earned promotion in the 2023-24 season. (AP)

Chelsea loses to Brighton as Champions League hopes hang by a thread



JAMES ROBSON ■ London

Chelsea's season slumped deeper into crisis after a 3-0 defeat to Brighton on Tuesday left its hopes of Champions League qualification hanging by a thread. The result leaves Chelsea seventh in the Premier League and seven points adrift of fifth place Liverpool having played a game more.

The top five qualify for the Champions League, but with just four more rounds of the season to go, Chelsea is on the verge of being cut adrift. Goals from Ferdi Kadioglu, Jack

Hinshelwood and Danny Welbeck at the AMEX Stadium did not reflect Brighton's dominance on the night. Victory saw it leapfrog Chelsea and move up to sixth in the standings and boosted its own pursuit of European soccer next season.

"That was unacceptable in every aspect of the game. Unacceptable in attitudes. I keep coming out and defending the players, that's indefensible that performance tonight," Chelsea coach Liam Rosenior told Sky Sports. "Something needs to change drastically." (AP)

Maradona's daughter assails doctor in negligence trial

SERGIO FARELLA
■ Buenos Aires (Argentina)

One of Diego Maradona's daughters lashed out at neurosurgeon Leopoldo Luque, who was considered her father's primary physician at the time of his death, during a negligence trial Tuesday.

Gianinna Maradona, in



a court in the Buenos Aires town of San Isidro, testified in the trial of seven medical professionals accused of negligence her father's death in 2020.

"I heard on television that he said he wasn't his doctor, and it makes me very angry that he won't take responsibility,"

Gianinna Maradona said. Luque and six others are standing a new trial because last May the court declared a mistrial after Julieta Makintach, one of the original three presiding judges, stepped down over criticism about her participation in a documentary on the case. (AP)

Venus Williams eyes French Open after a 10th straight loss

TALES AZZONI ■ Madrid

Venus Williams has her sights on the French Open. The 45-year-old former world No. 1 said Tuesday after losing her 10th straight singles match that she is considering playing at Roland Garros next month.

"Yeah, I mean, to get my feet dirty, this was a great start," she said in her post-match news conference at the Madrid Open.



"I'm not able to play Rome, I have other commitments, unfortunately, so I'm really super sad about that, actually. My husband is Italian, so we feel sad that we can't be there. So we would love to keep it going on the clay." Williams, a seven-time Grand Slam champion, lost 6-2, 6-4 to 20-year-old Spaniard Kaitlin Quevedo.

Williams hadn't played in Madrid in five years. Her last tournament

on clay had been at the 2021 French Open, when she lost her first match to Ekaterina Alexandrova.

"All these things take adjustments," Williams said. "I started my practice on clay a couple weeks after Miami. I haven't really played on clay in years. But I enjoy the clay, it's fun. I played against a very inspired opponent today."

Williams' last win on tour was against Peyton Stearns in the round of 16 of an WTA 500 event in Washington in July 2025. This year, she had already lost in Auckland, Hobart, the Australian Open, Austin, Indian Wells and Miami. (AP)

Caddies show their value in wins on the PGA Tour and LIV Golf



DOUG FERGUSON
■ Hilton Head Island (USA)

With so much emphasis on money and the trickle-down effect, sometimes the greatest reward for a caddy is the public credit given by their players. Matt Fitzpatrick won a thriller at the RBC Heritage in a playoff against Scottie Scheffler. On the 18th hole, from 204 yards into a stiff wind, Fitzpatrick hit 4-iron at the flag (OK, he says he slightly pulled it) that cleared the bunker and rolled out to 13 feet for the winning birdie.

The 18th hole Sunday was the first time all week he hit 4-iron, and only the second time he had the club in his bag (he didn't use it on Thursday). That it was there for him was due to his caddy, Daniel Parratt, because the wind was in the opposite direction from the previous three rounds.

"Great planning from Dan," Fitzpatrick said. "Just so aware of what's going on with the wind even before we

tee off and stuff. But I knew after the one in regulation (from a waste area), I had basically hit it as well as I could, and then in the fairway it was the same story.

"I knew I could just hit it. Fortunately, I hit a great shot." Jon Rahm had been in a mood during his pedestrian performance in the Masters (tie for 38th), and during the early days of LIV Golf Mexico City he had no interest in sharing what part of his game had cost him. But after closing with a 64 for a six-shot victory, he mentioned a session at Augusta National the previous week with caddy Adam Hayes.

"Adam and I nearly got in a heated argument on Saturday on the putting green at Augusta when he was trying to explain something and I wasn't fully understanding," Rahm said. "Once it clicked what he was trying to say and what I needed to work on on that range session Saturday afternoon, it was so much better." (AP)

A new 'Rafa' rises in Spain

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Madrid

Carlos Alcaraz is only 22 years old but there's already talk about the next generation of talented Spanish tennis players. And one of them has the same first name of all-time great Rafael Nadal — 19-year-old Rafael Jodar, who has been making headlines in Spain and across the tennis world thanks to a rapid rise through the rankings.

Jodar, who like Nadal also goes by the "Rafa" nickname, made it to the top 50 just ahead of his debut at the Madrid Open on Wednesday.

Another promising star is 20-year-old Martin Landaluce, who just recently broke into the top 100 in the men's rankings. They will be among the crowd favorites in the Spanish capital after Alcaraz withdrew because of a wrist injury.

"The two of them will mutually help each other to keep improving and reach the top," Alcaraz told the ATP Tour.



"They have a great future." Jodar was outside the top 600 just a year ago. He entered the top 100 in March and is up to No. 42 in the world in the latest ATP rankings released on Monday.

"I try to handle the pressure as I have done since I was little," Jodar said. "I've always been a very calm person both on and off the court. I know there'll be moments when things don't go as well as they have in recent tournaments. In those moments, you prove whether you're mentally strong. Those moments will also make me stronger."

Jodar advanced to the semifinals in Barcelona after three straight-set wins. He lost in three sets to eventual champion Arthur Fils in the semifinals. The Spaniard won his first tour-level trophy in Morocco earlier this month.

"I knew I was doing things right," Jodar said. "These last few months have gone very quickly for me and I've played a lot of matches. I can't say I could have imagined it. But I'm very happy to have started the clay swing like this, having played so many matches gives me a lot of confidence for this Madrid tournament."

SRH management, captain has backed me: Abhishek

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Abhishek Sharma believes that the game-changer in his career was the 2024 IPL season in Sunrisers Hyderabad when he felt youngsters were given the freedom and full backing to perform at their optimal level.

The world's Number 1 ranked T20 batter once again dazzled with an unbeaten 135 off 68 balls in SRH's 48 run win against Delhi Capitals.

"Team coaches (Daniel Vettori) and captain (regular skipper Pat Cummins) created an environment where you can express yourself. I wanted to show my talent but you have to have backing from captain. The environment we had in SRH in 2024 was game-changer and it felt that they wanted youngsters to grow. Punjabi players enjoy freedom and Hyderabad team gave me that," Abhishek said at the post match presentation.

His celebration was an ode to the 'Orange Army' and he also thanked his father Rajkumar Sharma for being present at the ground.

"One needs to pan the cameras on him (father) to catch his expressions. He always sits close to the sightscreen and whenever I look at him from the ground, he has an advice," he said jokingly.

On the game, he said that they had to plan differently as the pitch wasn't exactly a pure belter.

"The way we started, we had a plan to use the Powerplay. It was a bit slow and we had to replan, we had match ups in our mind. Always been special moment scoring at this special ground and you don't know par score till you play 20 overs."

His skipper Ishan Kishan was more than pleased to get a 200 plus total on this track.

"Don't have much to say when you have 200 plus score on a track where pitch gets slower and its not easy to hit. Discussions

THE WORLD'S NUMBER 1 RANKED T20 BATTER ONCE AGAIN DAZZLED WITH AN UNBEATEN 135 OFF 68 BALLS IN SRH'S 48 RUN WIN AGAINST DELHI CAPITALS

is to take match by match. We have to give ourselves 2-3 balls to understand how the pitch will play. We just watch the ball and play our game," said Kishan.

DC skipper Axar Patel rued about KL Rahul's bungling of a run-out and Pathum Nissanka dropping a sitter which allowed Abhishek to let loose.

"Run-out chance missed and missed catch did cost us dearly. Had we taken those chances, he wouldn't have reached where he did. But credit that he took those chances and scored those runs. But yes, good fielding is in our hands and we should have done that."

While DC's choice of players is being criticised, Axar ruled out any possibility of change in core set-up.

"Not thinking about making any changes. When wicket is so placid, we should just take this as an off day and forget about it," he told Sunil Gavaskar.



THE ENVIRONMENT WE HAD IN SRH IN 2024 WAS GAME-CHANGER AND IT FELT THAT THEY WANTED YOUNGSTERS TO GROW

Leading Indians in fray at Singapore Open golf



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Singapore

As many as 11 Indians, including Karandeep Kochhar, Gaganjeet Bhullar, SSP Chawrasia, and Jeev Milkha Singh, will tee off at the Singapore Open on Thursday, aiming to secure spots in the 154th edition of The Open Championship, golf's oldest Major, later this year.

The 57th edition of the tournament is part of the International Series and offers a prize purse of \$2 million, with the top two players — if not already exempt — earning spots in The Open Championship, scheduled for July.

Kochhar, in sublime form in recent months, will be one to watch. He is joined by 11-time Asian Tour winner Gaganjeet Bhullar, six-time winner SSP Chawrasia, and two-time Asian Tour Order of Merit champion Jeev Milkha Singh. Also in the fray are three-time Asian Tour winner Shiv Kapur, former champions Ajeetesh Sandhu and Rashid Khan, along with a promising young contingent featuring Pukhraj Singh Gill, Sachin Baisoya, Shaurya Bhattacharya, and Shubham Jaglan. The Singapore Open was last played at Sentosa

Golf Club in 2022, when Thailand's Sodom Kaewkanjana beat Tom Kim of Korea.

Apart from Sodom, the field this year also features several LIV Golf stars such as Lucas Herbert of Australia, Josele Ballester and Luis Masaveu of Spain, Americans Peter Uihlein and Caleb Surrratt and Sweden's Bjorn Hellgren.

Travis Smyth, who claimed the International Series Japan to take the lead on the Asian Tour Order of Merit (OOM) and The International Series Rankings, is back in action as well as reigning Merit champion Kazuki Higa of Japan.

Kochhar, who has been in close contention twice already this year, finishing fourth at the Philippine Golf Championship and fifth at International Series Japan, will look to capitalise on his rich vein of form.

"This is one tournament I look forward to, especially just in terms of the golf course. I think it's an amazing golf course and I love playing here. Hopefully I can play well," said Kochhar.

"I think it's a great track. It's a long golf course," he added. It's on the longer side for sure. But the conditions are great. I think it's going to be a hot, hot week," he added.

Dantewada moves beyond Maoist past, gets sports boost from Sachin

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dantewada

Cricket legend Sachin Tendulkar visited Chhattisgarh's Dantewada district on Wednesday to participate in an event as part of a grassroots sports initiative aimed at transforming the once Maoist-affected region into a thriving sports hub.

Tendulkar arrived at Jagdalpur airport and later travelled to Chhindnar village in Dantewada, where an event under the 'Maidan Cup' initiative is being held.

Talking to reporters at Jagdalpur airport, Tendulkar said, "I am very happy that we have developed around 50 school playgrounds (under the Maidan Cup initiative)."

He said a Maidan Cup competition is being held in Dantewada, supported by



the Mann Deshi and Sachin Tendulkar Foundation, benefiting more than 5,000 children.

According to district administration officials, it launched the Maidan Cup initiative in collaboration

with Mann Deshi and Sachin Tendulkar Foundation last year as part of efforts to shed the region's strife-torn

Ishan Kishan should continue leading SRH even after Pat Cummins returns: Bangar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Former India cricketer Sanjay Bangar has backed wicketkeeper batter Ishan Kishan to retain the Sunrisers Hyderabad captaincy even after the return of Australian Pat Cummins, pointing to his tactical acumen while leading the side this IPL season.

Bangar also raised questions over whether Cummins, for whom Ishan stood-in as captain in seven matches so far, can stay fit throughout the tournament as he returns from a near year-long injury layoff.

Cummins has recovered from a stress reaction in his lower back, which ruled him out of the T20 World Cup and delayed his start to the 2026 IPL, and is expected to return for Sunrisers Hyderabad against Rajasthan Royals in Jaipur on Saturday.

"Ishan Kishan as a leader is tactically very good in terms of how he uses his bowlers. He understands which bowlers to use against which batters. It is a clear marker of how well he controls the game. He



"ISHAN KISHAN AS A LEADER IS TACTICALLY VERY GOOD IN TERMS OF HOW HE USES HIS BOWLERS"

doesn't look clustered, is not hurried, and is taking the right calls on the field," Bangar, a former India batting coach, said on Star Sports.

"The way he used his spin-

ners against DC was impressive. All in all, I believe that even if Pat Cummins comes back, Ishan should continue captaining SRH. More often than not, having an Indian captain brings consistency.

Embarrassing Lucknow Super Giants undo Shami's effort to lose by 40 runs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants batters, led by their mercurial skipper Rishabh Pant, let Mohammed Shami's brilliant bowling effort go down the drain with an embarrassing 40-run defeat at the hands of an equally profligate Rajasthan Royals in an IPL match here on Wednesday. Chasing a target of 160, LSG huffed and puffed before being shot out for 119 in 18 overs after the slide started with their skipper Pant playing the most ugly sweep-cum-hoick to let the momentum slip after Shami, along with Mohsin Khan and Prince Yadav, had set up the platform for the hosts.

The decision to use a player like Himmat Singh as 'Impact Sub' will be questioned for the longest time as the player in nearly a decade of domestic cricket never won a SMAT game for Delhi with a career strike rate of 135 and less than a six per game. The win took Royals to the second spot with 10 points from seven games despite a shoddy batting effort.

Royals would be indebted to their 'OG' Ravindra Jadeja (43 no off 29 balls and 1/29) whose all-round effort went a long way in securing the win. His partnership with Shubham Dubey got them some kind of a total and then with the ball, he flung the data analysts' match-up card to remove Nicholas Pooran.

While Royals' batting has been inconsistent this season, the bowlers have been on the



From left, Rajasthan Royals' wicketkeeper Dhruv Jurel, Ravindra Jadeja and Shubham Dubey celebrate after winning the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 T20 cricket match between Lucknow Super Giants and Rajasthan Royals, in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh on Wednesday

money as Rishabh Pant was dismissed by Nandre Burger (2/27), and Jofra Archer (3/20) accounted for Aiden Markram with a rising delivery. This was after Ayush Badoni was unfortunately run-out.

Mitchell Marsh (55 off 41 balls) held the innings together even as likes of Nicholas Pooran and Himmat Singh went back playing some irresponsible shots. It was left to Mukul Choudhary, who still is a work in progress and haven't yet learnt how to tackle bouncers that grip off the surface. Earlier, Shami delivered a couple of beauties while Mohsin snuffed out teen sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to restrict Royals to a meagre 159 for 6

after opting to bowl. This is the third time in three games that Royals' top order has imploded and things have spiralled southwards for the franchise. The experience and class of Shami (2/30 in 4 overs) the Test bowler stood apart while the lanky Mohsin (2/17 in 4 overs) was extremely disciplined, getting the ball to rear up and seam at the same time from awkward lengths.

The duo between them removed the four best batters of Royals — Shami getting rid of Yashasvi Jaiswal (22) and Dhruv Jurel (0) off successive deliveries and Mohsin removing Sooryavanshi (8 off 11 balls) and Shimron Hetmyer (22 off 18 balls) in two different spells.

image and promote sports culture.

"It feels wonderful as our foundation with Mann Deshi team has been doing a good job here. I may play with the children as the sports event, which includes disciplines like kabaddi, kho-kho, athletics and volleyball, is being held," Tendulkar said.

Dantewada, once known for Maoist violence, including the 2010 ambush in Tadmeta (now in Sukma district) in which 76 security personnel were killed, is witnessing a shift. This initiative seeks to "reclaim childhood" and open new avenues for youth through sports, a district administration official said.

Chhattisgarh was declared free from Left-Wing Extremism on March 31 this year.

Under the Maidan Cup initiative, the target was to develop 50 playgrounds in

the first phase in Government schools, including high schools, higher secondary schools and porta cabin institutions, using low-cost models and community participation, the official said.

Facilities for 13 sports disciplines, including running tracks, shot put, javelin throw, discus throw, long jump and wall climbing, have been created. Each playground has been developed at a cost of less than Rs 4 lakh using locally available materials, he said.

Involving iconic figures like Tendulkar was aimed at inspiring children and encouraging community participation. Boundary walls of the playgrounds have been decorated with paintings by local children, he said. Playgrounds have already been completed in several villages, including Chhindnar, he added.

Abhishek's maturity unquestioned: Aaron

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad bowling coach Varun Aaron brushed aside any lack of maturity on the part of Abhishek Sharma even when he was going through a lean patch and lauded his sharp cricketing mind during his unbeaten 135 against Delhi Capitals in the IPL match in Hyderabad.

Abhishek batted from start to finish in SRH's emphatic 47 run win over Delhi Capitals on Tuesday, unleashing his full range of strokes to hammer an unbeaten 135 off 68 deliveries, anchoring the side's fourth win in seven games this season.

The young opener had endured a disastrous start at the T20 World Cup co-hosted by India and Sri Lanka earlier this year but found his groove at the business end to help India lift the trophy. He has carried that form into the IPL.

"I think he's always had that maturity and that's been there over the last couple of years. You can't be the number one T20 batsman in the world without being mature. Obviously, he's somebody who sees the opposition, sees the surface



and decides to play a certain way," said Aaron in the post-match press conference.

Aaron said Abhishek showed he has a sharp cricketing mind, batting with caution early on before shifting gears and going hard at the bowling.

"Today (Tuesday), it wasn't the surface where you could just go hell for leather every single ball. So you have to respect the opponent, you have to respect the surface and he (Abhishek) did exactly that," he said.

"And I think he's shown glimpses of this in the past but obviously when you play a high risk, high reward kind of a game, sometimes it doesn't work out and you have to give a player like Abhishek that leeway," added Aaron.